

THE QILVAYAS SYMPHONY

A Dungeons & Dragons 5th Edition Campaign Setting

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"I gaze upon the night sky admiring the stars strewn across Heaven's field. Each one a testament of power, its light piercing through the void to shine upon us. And now to our dawn light I summon you. Lord, have mercy upon us sinful children of Zhuvedus. Give us your light, Lord...and give me my destiny. I am Qilvayas, Emperor of the Zhuvedians. We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf."

—Prayer of Qilvayas on the eve of his coronation

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW

The Qilvayas Symphony is a campaign of imperial ambition, prophetic visions, and moral complexity set against the backdrop of a crumbling empire. Drawing inspiration from Byzantine history—particularly the struggles of emperors like Justinian who sought to restore former Roman glory—this campaign explores themes of legacy, power, the cost of idealism, and the tension between the dream of unity and the reality of a fractured world.

The player characters are final-year students at the prestigious Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, completing their field exercises and planning their futures as independent adventurers. When they receive a shared prophetic vision of the capital city in flames and a monstrous shadow in storm clouds above, they are drawn into events that will test their abilities, challenge their loyalties, and potentially determine the fate of the empire itself.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

THE HEIGHT OF EMPIRE

At its zenith, the Empire of Zhuvedus spanned nearly an entire continent. United under the Lupine Throne and guided by the principles of the Lupine Matron, the empire represented civilization, law, and order. The Golden Tablets—sacred legal codes established by the empire's forefathers—formed the foundation of Zhuvedian governance and culture. Trade flourished along imperial roads, justice was administered by trained magistrates, and the imperial legions defended the borders against external threats.

The imperial capital, seat of the Lupine Throne, was the beating heart of this civilization—a center of learning, culture, and power that drew the ambitious and talented from across the realm.

TWO CENTURIES OF DECLINE

The empire's decline was not sudden but gradual—a slow erosion over two hundred years. Internal strife between noble houses weakened central authority. Corruption spread through the bureaucracy as distant provinces found ways to avoid imperial taxation and oversight. Military expeditions to reclaim lost territories or suppress rebellions failed, draining the treasury and damaging the legions' reputation. External powers, sensing weakness, pressed against the borders and even seized imperial territory.

Most devastatingly, the empire fractured. What had been provinces became semi-independent "nations," each ruled by ambitious warlords, merchant councils, or noble houses who once swore fealty to the throne but now pursued their own interests. Some maintained the fiction of imperial loyalty while ignoring imperial law. Others openly declared independence. Still others warred among themselves, creating a patchwork of competing powers where once there had been unity.

The imperial capital remained, and the Lupine Throne was still occupied, but the reach of imperial authority had shrunk dramatically. The empire existed more in memory and aspiration than in reality.

THE EMPIRE OF ZHUVEDUS: CURRENT STATE

POLITICAL LANDSCAPE

The empire today is a shadow of its former self, yet it persists. The imperial capital and its surrounding territories remain under direct imperial control, and several regions still recognize the Lupine Throne's authority—some genuinely, others opportunistically. The fractured "nations" present a complex political landscape:

Border Lords and Regional Powers: Former provincial governors, military commanders, and noble houses now rule territories as de facto independent states. Their relationship with the throne varies—some maintain nominal loyalty while ignoring imperial edicts, others have declared independence outright, and a few actively work against reunification to protect their autonomy.

Merchant Republics: Wealthy trading cities that broke away to avoid imperial taxation, now governed by councils of merchants and guild masters. They prefer the current disorder, which allows them to play different powers against each other for commercial advantage.

Warlord Territories: Regions held by military strongmen who rose to power during the empire's collapse. Some style themselves as protectors of order, others are little better than bandits with armies.

Imperial Loyalists: Territories that still genuinely support the throne, either out of tradition, religious conviction in the Lupine Matron's divine mandate, or pragmatic belief that a restored empire offers better stability than the current chaos.

The borders are fluid and contested. Alliances shift, minor wars flare up and sputter out, and ambitious lords constantly scheme for advantage. Into this volatile situation steps Emperor Qilvayas with his vision of restoration.

ATLAS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

The territories below are the ones most likely to matter in the campaign's first arcs — not an exhaustive map. Distances by imperial road: the Ostmark is four days east of Aenodira, the Brekelands roughly two weeks west, Tarnovar three weeks into the western highlands, Velmareth ten days downriver.

The Crownlands: The imperial core — Aenodira, its river valley, and the districts within a week's march — under direct rule and the only place imperial law functions at full strength. Prosperous by current standards, anxious by any other measure: everyone in the Crownlands lives inside the restoration project, whether they believe in it or not. Capital culture runs on the race-days of the Long Course, where the city's two great factions — the Golds and the Greys, named for the stone of the walls they claim — turn sport into politics and politics into sport (see Plot Hooks: The Grey-Gold Rising).

The Ostmark: The eastern march, held by thin legion garrisons and thick tradition. Loyalist by conviction in the towns (Dravenna among them) and by inertia in the countryside. The Third Provincial Legion scandal — Colonel Aurel Dessen, who sold his garrison's grain and blamed the men who fled — is exactly the kind of rot that decides whether places like this stay loyal. Magistrate Cassivar Ondrei's complaint about it is somewhere in a capital inbox. The march's pride, and the throne's quiet anxiety, is Marshal Gavric Dane (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), the young commander who brought a lost wolf-standard home.

The Suthmark: The southern breadbasket, genuinely loyalist and deeply devout — the Matron's faith runs older and plainer here than in the capital: harvest processions, field-shrines, saints' days kept by planting calendars. Governed by Duchess Emerenn Vasq (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), Velmareth-born and iron beneath the mourning silk, whose loyalty is sincere and whose patience is not unlimited. The south still carries two scars it does not discuss with outsiders: the Vintage Night, six years past, and the hill country around Castle Greywell, where servant girls have a way of not coming home.

Principality of Tarnovar: A highland nation in the far west, openly independent for a century and pointedly uninterested in reunification. Tarnovari culture is built on the given word: oaths are sworn on standing stones rather than gods, oath-breaking is the one unforgivable crime, and their oldest ballads mourn a betrayed lord called Vosthren, whose story no imperial scholar has ever bothered to trace. Their proverb for treating with the throne: "Never again the wolf's word." Ruled by the aging, canny Voivode Ysavet Morn — whose word is absolute everywhere except the Eastmarch, where her kinsman Ban Dregan Morn keeps the border with the Brekelands by methods she has never sanctioned and never stopped (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire).

DM Only: Tarnovar is what became of Threnvos's people. "Vosthren" is Threnvos, syllable-inverted by twenty centuries of oral drift — a name the Church never thought to suppress because it never recognized it. The Tarnovari do not know their own true origin; their stone-oath customs and their instinctive distrust of imperial promises are cultural scar tissue from a wound no living person can name. This is a mid-campaign revelation of enormous weight: proof of the buried founding account exists in living culture, not just old stones — and depending on how it surfaces, Tarnovar becomes the empire's natural ally against the shadow or the rightful claimant its founding wronged. Handle with care; do not spend it early.

Free City of Velmareth and the Delta Compact: The great merchant republic of the river delta and the league of trading towns in its orbit. Rich, ostentatiously neutral, and quietly committed to the fractured status quo — disorder is margin. The Merchant Republic delegations at Aenodira's Exchange answer, eventually, to Velmareth's Harborlords — among whose great banking houses the Meldane name still opens every door, a fact of continuing relevance to the Suthmark (see Duchess Emerenn Vasq).

The Brekelands: The broken middle-west: a patchwork of warlord holdings where imperial administration simply stopped. The local trouble is the Granary War — warlords Bettra Skarn and Ilmarch Voss burning each other's villages over a dispute neither remembers clearly — which produced the Halvenne refugees and three other burned villages this season. But the Granary War is a squabble between men who cannot see the weather coming: from the west, Duke Garvin Norr absorbs one warlord holding after another into Normere's Reckoning Book, and along the eastern hills runs Ban Dregan's Fence, which no Brekeland company raids past twice.

The See of Orlath: A breakaway patriarchate in the north claiming the purer doctrine of the Matron — founded some forty-five years ago by Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), a woman whose road to sanctity ran through one of the most terrible vengeance in northern memory. Orlath recognizes neither the Matriarchate's authority nor the Office of Omens' monopoly on the divine will, and refugees of conscience — clergy who fell out with the Sanctum — drift there still. What the capital has not yet understood: Orlath is no longer merely a schism. It is preparing a coronation.

Kingdom of Ardven: The young power of the far north, beyond Orlath: a dozen quarrelsome kingdoms and clanlands hammered into one crown over fifteen years by King Karvel (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire). Ardven is expansionist, literate, and increasingly confident — Karvel plants monastery schools the way other kings plant fortresses, and his court hosts scholars the empire's academies lost to poverty or politics. His consolidation of the northern coasts has had one consequence the empire feels directly: the ship-clans of the Skellvard, driven from fjords they held for generations, now raid southward with nowhere to return to.

The Skellvard: Sea-lords raiding the imperial coast in growing strength — but raiders is only half the truth. The Skell ship-clans are a displaced people, pushed from their northern harbors by Ardven's expansion, led by Sea-King Aldrec the Landless (see The Powers of the Fractured Empire), who once served the empire and was cheated for it. Skell culture keeps tally-sticks of every debt owed and every promise broken; their raids are recorded, clan by clan, as

collections. Their kings are buried beneath rivers, in secret, so that no enemy may ever stand on a Skell king's grave — a people whose deepest fear is having nowhere to be buried at all.

The Duchy of Normere: The iron surprise of the west coast: a once-minor duchy forged into the most efficient state in the fractured empire by Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard of Normere (see *The Powers of the Fractured Empire*). Normere's instruments are famous and feared in equal measure — the Reckoning Book, a census of every hide of land and head of livestock the Duke rules; the personal oath every landholder swears to Norr himself, bypassing all intermediate lords; and the memory of the Harrowing of the Weld, four years past, when a rebellious district learned what the Duke's patience costs when it runs out. Norr is not resisting reunification. He is conducting his own.

THE REGIONS IN DEPTH

Per the approved full-fantasy dial: monsters are common, dragons are active, and the wild is genuinely wild. Creature lists name SRD monsters except where marked † (Monster Manual, non-SRD — validate manually per instructions). Each region: the land, who lives there, what hunts there, and named settlements.

THE CROWNLANDS

The land: the Ostrun's broad valley — terraced grain, cypress windbreaks, poplar-lined imperial roads, and the capital's three walls rising out of river haze. Old, worked, beautiful, tired. Peoples: Zhuvedian humans, Coppergate halflings, the masons' dwarves, faded high-elf houses, the Craft's gnomes — and the dynasty, alone in its blood. Creatures: mostly human dangers, plus the city's famous exceptions — wererats† in Rivergate's deep cellars (the Watch denies it; the Inkhands charge a surcharge for jobs below the waterline), the Garrison's last three griffons (the wing was forty strong at the height of empire; the riders' hall keeps every empty saddle oiled), and the wolves of Aenodira — sacred, protected, and (DM only) leaving the Old Forum district family by family for three years. Settlements: Aenodira (canon); Varn's Crossing (canon — the toll bridge); Lupenna, a pilgrim town at the Matron's first roadside shrine, all candle-stalls and wolf-icons; Whitequay, a river town that ships the valley's grain and remembers when it shipped ten times more.

THE OSTMARK

The land: big-sky plains breaking into wooded hills eastward, watch-forts on the heights (Redwatch was one of a chain — most now stand empty), and the trade road running through it all like a nerve. Peoples: Ostfolk humans and the marches' respected half-orc veteran families; a legion culture even where the legions are thin. Creatures: wolf packs (read for omens), worgs where the old auxiliary kennels went feral, ogres in the hill country, ankhegs in the grain flats, griffons nesting the crags (the legions once took eggs under license; nobody has dared in a generation), and wights†-and-worse in the failed watch-forts — dead garrisons make bad neighbors, and the shadow's stirring is making them restless. Settlements: Dravenna (canon); Kolvess, the Third Legion's garrison town, where Colonel Dessen's name is said carefully; Serren's Mill, a crossroads village famous for poppy-milk and for minding its own business.

THE SUTHMARK

The land: golden grain to the horizon, vineyard terraces, chalk downs, and — eastward — the grey hollows of the Greywell hills, where the light arrives late and leaves early. Peoples: devout Suthfolk humans, halfling harvest-clans, hill dwarves in the east (whose families have learned the valley's law does not climb). Creatures: ankhegs (the grain country's classic plague — harvest-festival effigies are shaped like them), giant boars, blights in the old orchards, a confirmed green hag somewhere in the Greywell watershed (the valley folk leave her be, on the reasonable grounds that she is not the worst thing in those hills), and harvest-fey of the Old Observance — sprites and a dryad grove the Church politely does not discuss. Settlements: Caldesa, the ducal seat — wine, mourning-silk, and the Garland's quiet ears in every kitchen; Ambervale, a harvest town that hosts the south's great festival (and was one of the three towns of the Vintage Night — the festival has a new route now, avoiding certain streets); Greywell-under-Hill, the village at the castle's feet, where the wages are good.

PRINCIPALITY OF TARNOVAR

The land: the empire's deep wilderness — montane mist-forest rising to bare stone, the standing-stone rings on the bald summits, valleys where noon looks like evening. The Old Wood at its heart is the largest unbroken forest in the fractured world. Peoples: Tarnovari humans and the Stonesworn dwarves (a third of the nation, fully Tarnovari), wood-elf communities deep in the Old Wood keeping the eldest ballads — including, unknowing, the truest ones. Creatures: owlbeats, ettercaps and their webs in the pine deeps, green hags at the fey margins, elk and giant elk, winter wolves on the high passes — and the Old Wood's fey-touched heart, where the Hollow Hills stand and travelers' time runs strange (a soft Feywild adjacency, never named onstage). Settlements: Kamenhold, the Voivode's seat, built dry-stone into a mountainside — the oath-stones of every Tarnovari family stand in its high field; Fencegate, Ban Dregan's border fort on the Eastmarch, beyond which the stakes begin; Verath, an Old Wood village of singers — Ilinca's home — where the Lament cycle is kept whole.

FREE CITY OF VELMARETH AND THE DELTA COMPACT

The land: the Ostrun's delta — reed-seas, tidal channels, and the lagoon city itself: Velmareth on its ten thousand pilings, all bridges, salt-stained marble, and money. Peoples: everyone — the true cosmopolis; Velmarene humans and half-elves, halfling middle guilds, Marked (tiefling) quarters with actual legal standing, Sarkanni mercenary lodges, and anything the tide brings. Creatures: giant crocodiles in the reed-sea, merrow in the outer channels (the Compact pays a 'channel-toll' it does not describe in its ledgers), water elementals bound as harbor-engines by chartered thaumaturges, swarms of everything — and, in the drowned quarter's oldest cellars, things the Harborlords' dredge-teams are paid triple to not discuss. Settlements: Velmareth itself; Saltmark, the Compact's toll-town at the delta mouth; Reedhaven, a stilt-village of pilots and smugglers who are often the same families.

THE BREKELANDS

The land: broken hill country — hedgerows gone wild between burned granges, mill-streams turning no wheels, roads that fork around the ruins of villages that were the reason for the roads. Peoples: Brekelander humans — tough,

displaced, warlord-taxed — and everyone's deserters. Creatures: the war's harvest — gnolls (famine-born packs following the burnings; the old folk say gnolls are what hunger prays to), ghouls and ghouls at the burn sites (betrayal-fed dead: Halvenne's ashes are already whispered about), wyverns in the high crags taking cattle and the occasional tax-collector, and manticores that learned to follow armies. (DM only: the ghoul-density at parley-breach sites is not natural, and it is rising. The Brekelands are the shadow's best-fed province outside the capital.) Settlements: Skarnhold and Vosskeep, the rival warlord seats, each convinced it is the reasonable one; Millbreak, a neutral market town that survives by being useful to everyone and loyal to no one — the Brekelands in one village.

THE SEE OF ORLATH

The land: taiga edge and fell-country — pilgrim roads switchbacking to the mountain city, prayer-cairns at every false summit, and the Reconciliation Shrine above the treeline where Olvesa spent her year. Peoples: Orlathine humans — penitent, rigorous, warmer than their liturgy — and clergy refugees from every Sanctum quarrel of the last forty years. Creatures: winter wolves (Orlath reads them as the Matron's northern honor guard and feeds them at the pilgrim stations — a practice the Sanctum calls heresy and the wolves call dinner), polar bears and saber-cats on the high fells, trolls in the ravines, banshees† on the Drevic moors — the old clan-lands never quite finished grieving — and ice mephits in the shrine-heights. Settlements: Orlath, the see-city, carved switchback galleries and the Second Treasury of Relics; Penitent's Stair, the last town before the Shrine, economy of candles, crutches, and confessions; Drevholm, the quiet town on the old clan-lands, where nobody sings.

KINGDOM OF ARDVEN

The land: fjords and pine-clad steeples, longhouse towns turning to slate-roofed monastery burghs as Karvel's new order spreads — the north mid-transformation, timber to stone, saga to script. Peoples: Ardvener humans, wood-elf enclaves in the wilds, dwarven quarry-towns under royal charter. Creatures: the Fjell Whites — a brood of young white dragons in the high ranges that Karvel's rangers cull like wolves-of-state (an adult matriarch is unconfirmed; the rangers' silence on the question is its own answer); frost giants in the far fells, with whom Karvel maintains a tribute-truce he finds humiliating and keeps anyway; trolls, winter wolves, mammoths on the tundra edge; and giant eagles that the northern kings once flew — Karvel is trying to revive the mews, because of course he is. Settlements: Karvholm, the new capital — half longhouse, half cathedral, all ambition; Lettervik, the monastery town where forty schools' worth of scribes are teaching the north to write; Fjellgard, the ranger town under the dragon-fells, quietly the toughest place in the kingdom.

THE SKELLVARD

The land: not land — the cold sea itself, island anchorages, whale-roads, and the drowned fjords the clans lost to Ardvén's expansion. The Skell live aboard; the fleets are the nation. Peoples: Skell humans — salt-cured, tally-keeping, courteous in the way of people who remember everything. Creatures: hunter sharks and killer whales (clan-omens), merrow war-bands (old enemies, old treaties), harpies on the guano stacks, a plesiosaurus breed the clans call sea-elk and herd — herd — and, beneath the Weeping Strait, the Saltmaw (see Part VI). Settlements (such as they are): the Gathering Roads, the great fleet-moot in the lee of the Broken Isles, a

city that exists two months a year; Wrecksalt Isle, the beaching-ground, shipwright's yard, and the closest thing the landless have to holy ground — no king is buried there; that is the point of it.

THE DUCHY OF NORMERE

The land: rain-lashed headlands, drained polder-fields behind the Duke's dikes (the Reckoning Book records every sluice), slate towns of ruthless neatness, and castles placed like arguments. Peoples: Normerine humans — administered, prosperous, watchful — and hired dwarven stonewrights on chartered terms. Creatures: the coast's merrow and sahuagin raiders (Norr's shore-levies drill against them monthly; attendance is recorded), wights in the pre-ducal barrows (Norr's surveyors map them and build around, to the letter of an old accommodation nobody writes down) — and the Weld. (DM only: the Harrowing left revenants† — vengeance-oath dead — walking the burned district. Norr knows. The Weld is the one entry in the Reckoning Book with no numbers in it, and the one place his personal oath-web has a hole in it. The shadow has noticed the hole.) Settlements: Norr's Watch, the ducal seat — the Reckoning Book's hall is open to any sworn subject, which is either transparency or the largest threat ever bound in vellum; Slateharrow, the naval port; the Weld, which is on the maps and off the itineraries.

DRAGONS OF THE FRACTURED AGE

VESSARKATH THE PATIENT — THE SILVASSE WEALD

Ancient green dragon (SRD), and the true author of the Silvasse Disaster: sixty years ago, three legions marched into her wood — hers for eight centuries — and she did what patience does. She has slept on their eagles ever since, which reframes canon without contradicting it: Marshal Dane's recovery of the Ninth's standard from 'the Brekelands warlords' stands — the warlords had it because Vessarkath let one standard leave her hoard, through channels, sixty years after taking it. Why she permitted this is DM-only and deliberately open: greens play generational games, and a beloved young marshal now owes his legend to a dragon's unexplained generosity — a fact precisely one creature in the world can ever tell him. She does not raid; she does not treat; she receives. The Brekelands warlords' unspoken western border is not Norr. It was never Norr.

THE SALTMAW — THE WEEPING STRAIT

Dragon turtle (SRD), old beyond clan-memory, dwelling beneath the strait where the empire spent three thousand Skell lives. The clans propitiate it with the salt-tithe — cargo given to the water at the strait's mouth — and its interventions are weather to them: unpredictable, unappealable, occasionally merciful. DM-option, flagged within a flag: what the imperial admiral's squadrons actually fled at the Weeping Strait — the battle canon leaves unspecified — may have been the Saltmaw rising. If adopted, Aldrec's people were spent not against raiders but as a distraction offered to a leviathan, which sharpens his grievance from cruelty to sacrilege. If not adopted, the Saltmaw is simply the strait's terrible fact and the tithe's reason.

THE FJELL WHITES — THE ARDVEN RANGES

A brood of young white dragons (SRD) in the high north — Karvel's standing predator-control problem, culled by the Fjellgard rangers like wolves-of-state. The unconfirmed adult matriarch is the north's quiet dread and a ready-made mid-campaign escalation: if she exists and wakes, Ardven's working restoration meets its first problem that cannot be administered, audited, or crowned away — timed, if the DM wishes, terribly close to the coronation.

RUMORS OF WINGS (PLAYER-FACING TEXTURE, D6)

d6	Rumor (and the truth)
1	'Gold seen over the Velmareth delta at dusk.' (A wyvern flock in low sun. Merchants embellish.)
2	'The Saltmaw took a Compact grain-ship whole.' (True. The ship had skipped the tithe two years running.)
3	'A white wing over Karholm itself.' (A young Fjell White, lost in cloud, gone by morning — but Karvel doubled the rangers.)
4	'The Silvasse eats compasses. And legions.' (Both, in a sense, true.)
5	'There is a dragon under Aenodira.' (False — and the DM should let players chew this one, because what is under Aenodira is worse, and the rumor is the city's way of almost knowing it.)
6	'The Matron's own wolf flies on nights of the dark moon.' (Faith, not zoology. Probably.)

COMMERCE: SHOPS AND PRICE TABLES

All mundane prices pulled from the SRD equipment data (exact book values). Magic availability per the approved economy: Church almonries sell sanctioned mercy openly; arcane material is chartered, scarce, and papered; Rivergate discounts everything including the truth.

THE EXCHANGE, AENODIRA — GENERAL OUTFITTING (BOOK PRICES)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Backpack	2 gp	Rope, hempen (50 ft.)	1 gp
Bedroll	1 gp	Rations (1 day)	5 sp

Lantern, hooded	5 gp	Oil (flask)	1 sp
Torch	1 cp	Tinderbox	5 sp
Crowbar	2 gp	Grappling hook	2 gp
Chain (10 ft.)	5 gp	Waterskin	2 sp
Mirror, steel	5 gp	Caltrops (bag)	1 gp
Healer's Kit	5 gp	Climber's Kit	25 gp

THE GARRISON QUARTERMASTER — ARMS & ARMOR (LICENSE INSPECTED, PRICES BOOK)

Item	Price	Item	Price
Shortsword	10 gp	Longsword	15 gp
Shield	10 gp	Chain Shirt	50 gp
Breastplate	400 gp	Crossbow, light	25 gp
Arrows (20)	1 gp	Spear	1 gp

SCHOLAR'S ROW & THE CHURCH ALMONRY — THE SANCTIONED TRADE

Item	Price	Notes
Potion of Healing (stamped)	50 gp	Church almonry; the stamp is the Sanction — possession of unstamped potions invites questions
Potion of Greater Healing	200 gp	Requires standing with a parish, or a pilgrim's writ
Holy water (flask)	25 gp	Book price; Orlathine-blessed flasks trade at a premium or a discount depending on the buyer's politics
Spell scroll, 1st level	100 gp	Chartered scriptorium; purchaser entered in the register
Spell scroll, 2nd level	300 gp	As above, plus a thaumaturgical reference
Component pouch	25 gp	Book price
Ink (1 oz.) /	10 gp / 2 sp	Book prices;

Paper (sheet)		Scholar's Row runs on both
Spellbook (blank, bound)	50 gp	Book price
Blessed taper (homebrew, common)	5 gp	Burns 1 hour; its light counts as the light of a shrine for purposes of the Old Observance — mostly bought for funerals and promises

RIVERGATE GRAY MARKET — 'EVERYTHING CERTIFIED'

Item	Price	Notes
Any Exchange-list item	–20%	Provenance flexible; quality genuine (the Inkhands guarantee it — their ledgers are their honor)
Unstamped healing potion	35 gp	Works fine. The discount is the legal risk, priced honestly
Unlicensed scrollwork, 1st	60–80 gp	1-in-6 chance of a flawed casting (DM discretion); the good scribes cost Exchange prices anyway
'Relic' of a named saint	10–500 gp	Almost always false. Almost. (See Part I: the false-relic trade, and the terrifying occasional exception)
Dead-office seals & instruments	Negotiable	Mosse's shop — see Session Five; prices are sentimental

REGIONAL SIGNATURE VENDORS

Vendor	Where	Specialty & Sample Prices
Ostwatch Outfitters (Yanna's cousin's house)	Dravenna	Road & cold-weather gear at book; caravan intelligence free with purchase; wolf-charms 1 sp ('for luck, and it's bad luck not to')
The Stonewright's Yard	Kamenhold	Dwarven-forged tools +10% (worth it);

		Oathstone Charms 5 gp (see Part VIII homebrew); dry-stone masonry consulting, priced in favors
The Vintners' Hall	Caldessa	Suthmark vintages 1–50 gp; mourning-silk; and the Garland hears every order placed
The Letter-House	Lettervik	Books 25 gp+, maps of the north 10 gp, copying services; Karvel's subsidy makes literacy cheap — the point is the point
The Tithe-Factor	Saltmark	Ship passage, cargo insurance (Saltmaw exclusions in small print), Skell tally-sticks as negotiable instruments

THE LUPINE MATRON AND IMPERIAL FAITH

The Lupine Matron is the divine patron of the Zhuvedian Empire, represented as a great wolf—wise, protective, and fierce. According to Zhuvedian theology, the Lupine Matron gave the empire's people their core virtues: loyalty, honor, wisdom, and the strength to endure hardship. The phrase "We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf" references this divine connection and appears in imperial prayers and ceremonies.

The Matron's worship long predates the empire that now venerates her. Zhuvedian doctrine holds that she has guided many champions and many peoples across a span of time far longer than any dynasty's recorded history—Zhuvedus was simply the most successful and most enduring of those she chose to favor. Whether Zhuvedus himself ever attained true divinity, however, is a matter of genuine theological dispute, one that runs directly through the empire's politics and its faith alike (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath).

The faith of the Lupine Matron has historically unified the empire, providing moral and spiritual justification for imperial authority. The Golden Tablets, containing the fundamental laws of the empire, are said to have been inspired by the Lupine Matron's wisdom and committed to writing by the empire's forefathers.

However, as the empire fractured politically, regional variations in the faith have emerged. Some breakaway territories emphasize different aspects of the Lupine Matron's teachings or venerate local saints above imperial doctrine. This theological fragmentation mirrors the political

splintering and presents both a challenge and an opportunity for Qilvayas's restoration efforts.

The Church of the Lupine Matron in the capital remains the institutional heart of the faith—wealthy, hierarchical, and deeply entangled with imperial politics. Its clergy administer doctrine, sanctify imperial authority, and guard their interpretive monopoly over omens, visions, and the divine will. Those who claim direct revelation outside Church sanction occupy dangerous ground: not quite heretical, but never fully tolerated. This tension becomes immediately relevant to the party through the Seeress (see Key NPCs and Factions).

THE CHURCH IN PRACTICE

The capital Church is governed by the Matriarchate — Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane as the Voice of the Matron in Aenodira — advised (and constrained) by the Synod of the Grey, a council of senior clergy whose sessions are closed and whose politics are not. Beneath them: the seminaries of the Sanctum, the parish structure that reaches into every district and most loyalist provinces, and the Office of Omens, headed by Prelate Sarvin Odell, which claims sole authority to receive, examine, and rule on visions, portents, and claims of divine contact. The Office's method is bureaucratic rather than cruel — polite reception, separate questioning, a written determination — and its determinations have a way of ending in files rather than answers. It resents Vaelindra's existence the way a licensing board resents an unlicensed master: not because she is fraudulent, but because she is not theirs. And under Odell, resentment has recently become policy: as unsanctioned claims multiply across the fracturing empire, the Office has moved from keeping files to serving writs — its posture toward Vaelindra, and toward anyone publicly associated with her, is now active interference rather than watchful patience (engaged in Sessions Five and Six).

THE KEEPERS OF THE ASCENT (IMPERIAL CULT)

The imperial cult's formal body is small: the Keepers of the Ascent, a priesthood of perhaps forty, led by Hierophant Malzeth Corr, maintaining the dynastic shrine within Highcourt and the doctrine that Zhuvedus rose to divinity and his line carries the spark of it. The Keepers serve the throne's legitimacy and know it; the Church tolerates them and both institutions understand exactly why. Qilvayas's own relationship to the cult is correct rather than warm — he performs the dynastic rites because an emperor must, and the question of whether he privately believes them is one his court has learned not to ask.

DEATH, THE VIGIL, AND THE HALLS OF THE DEAD

Doctrine is specific about one thing across every schism, every breakaway see, every province that argues about everything else: the Matron watches the dead home, and she does it at night. No Zhuvedian burns, buries, or gives a body to the water before it has been kept through at least one full night's Vigil — watched, lit, and never left alone — because a soul let into the dark unwatched is a soul the Matron might lose track of, and doctrine is not interested in finding out whether that's literally true. This is the one funerary practice that travels unchanged from the capital's golden dome to the furthest Ardden monastery-burgh: something recognizably

vigil-shaped happens everywhere, even where almost nothing else about the rite matches.

What happens after the Vigil is where the empire stops agreeing with itself, the same way it stops agreeing about everything else once you leave the Crownlands. Aenodira interns its dead in the Bone Galleries beneath the Old Forum, centuries deep, oldest at the bottom — a practice old enough to predate the Church's involvement in it. (The public stairs on the Forum's east side serve the upper galleries only; the deeper levels have been closed 'for consolidation' since before living memory, and the vigil-keepers do not ask — which keeps the funerary traffic entirely clear of the route established in Session Six.) The Suthmark folds burial into the planting calendar: the devout are put into the ground on saints' days tied to sowing or harvest, on the theory that a soul returned to the earth on the right day helps the next year's grain along. Tarnovar barely buries at all in the imperial sense — a dead Tarnovari's oaths, not their body, are what the living formally inherit, spoken aloud at the standing stones by whoever takes up the unfinished promise, while the body itself goes to the Old Wood by older and less documented means. Velmareth, characteristically, sends its dead into the reed-sea on lit barges and calls the crocodiles a hazard rather than a horror.

For an ordinary market town with no catacombs and no delta to send anyone into, the physical answer is the Vigil Hall — a modest, unglamorous building near the local shrine or almonry, kept by lay vigil-keepers (traditionally widowed or elderly, traditionally paid almost nothing, traditionally among the best-informed people in town about who just died owing what to whom). Every major town has one. It is exactly the kind of small, load-bearing institution that can hold a scene, a rumor, or a body the party very badly needs to examine, without a word of this needing to touch the Undercourt, the binding site, or anything else still sealed for later.

MAGIC AND THE WORD

THE WEIGHT OF THE WORD

The setting's metaphysical signature, formalized: in the world of the Lupine Matron, sworn words have literal weight. An oath spoken with intent creates a real, thin binding — imperceptible to almost everyone, cumulative across a civilization, and the reason this world's history keeps rhyming. It is why the Tarnovari swear on stone (stone holds what air forgets), why Ban Dregan's Fence works on the level of dread as well as deterrence, why Duke Norr's tens of thousands of personal oaths constitute a strategic reality, why the Church treats vows as sacraments and the law treats perjury as blasphemy's cousin — and why the breaking of the first great covenant could birth a god-sized wound. Mechanically this changes nothing: no new rules, no new subsystems. It is the flavor layer that makes every class, spell, and social contract in 5e feel native to this world rather than imported into it.

DIVINE MAGIC AND THE SANCTION

Divine magic flows from the Matron — genuinely. Clerics, paladins, and divine casters channel her power exactly as the rules describe, and the power is real regardless of what any institution rules about it. What the Church of the Lupine Matron claims is not the source but the license: the Sanction, its asserted sole authority to ordain who may lawfully

channel, interpret, or minister. A sanctioned cleric carries a pewter warrant-medal; an unsanctioned healer in Church lands is a theological problem that the Office of Omens exists, in large part, to solve. The See of Orlath issues its own rival sanction — which means the fractured empire has two licensing authorities for the same living goddess, and she has conspicuously declined to rule on the dispute: both churches' clerics keep their spells. The DM-facing joke is quiet and total: the Matron answers everyone who calls sincerely, and the institutions have built two empires of paperwork on top of her silence.

CHARTERED THAUMATURGY — THE ARCANES

The academy already treats magic as “a specialized skill like any other” (canon), and this pass extends that to the empire's whole arcane culture: wizardry is chartered, credentialed, and bureaucratized wonder — the Byzantine relationship to engineering, applied to the impossible. A Chartered Thaumaturge of the House of the Craft holds a license enumerating the schools they may practice and the wards they may raise; the Charter is prestige, employability, and legal cover in one document. Outside the charter system live the hedge-mages — village workers of small practical magic, tolerated exactly as long as nothing goes wrong — and Rivergate's gray market in unlicensed scrollwork, where the penalty structure has taught practitioners to be very good or very quick. Sorcerers (“the Kindled”) sit awkwardly across all categories: power without study reads to the chartered as cheating and to the Church as a question, and bloodline fire in a world of covenant-metaphysics invites the obvious whisper — whose old bargain are you carrying?

WARLOCKS: THE SWORN

A pact is an oath, and a warlock is a person who swore one to something that answered. In this setting that makes warlocks theologically radioactive in Church lands — not because their power is necessarily evil, but because an unexamined covenant is precisely the category of thing this world's buried history proves can end civilizations. The Office of Omens keeps a standing file classification for suspected pact-bearers. Velmareth, characteristically, keeps a fee schedule instead. (DM note: warlock patrons should be built carefully in this setting — every patron relationship is a live wire running near the campaign's central mechanism, and at least one patron option, developed later with sign-off, could knowingly or unknowingly trace back to the thing beneath Aenodira.)

THE OLD OBSERVANCE

Druids and rangers practice the faith's pre-imperial stratum — the Matron as she was worshipped before there was an empire to sanction anything: field-shrines, first-fruits, the wolf-watch on winter roads. The Suthmark's harvest processions and planting-calendar saints' days (canon) are the domesticated descendant of this; in Tarnovar's Old Wood and the Ardden fells it survives undomesticated. The Church's position on the Old Observance is studied non-comment: it cannot condemn practices older than its own doctrine without inviting questions about what else predates doctrine — a nervousness the DM knows is better-founded than the Synod does.

SCARRED GROUND

Magic is scarred where great betrayals happened. Wards will not anchor at the Cold Door (canon); the same principle generalizes gently across the world: sites of oath-breaking at scale — massacre-fields under parley signs, the Weld, the deeps beneath the Old Forum — resist beneficial magic, sour divination, and hold cold. Practitioners call such places thin-written. No mechanical subsystem: adjudicate as environmental flavor with occasional concrete effects (disadvantage on a ritual here, a divination returning grief instead of answers there), always as story.

THE SHE-WOLF OF THE NIGHT SKY

The Matron's iconography is lunar and nocturnal: the She-Wolf of the Night Sky, the moon her watching eye, the stars her pack, dawn her gift rather than her element. The coronation prayer's address to the night sky is theologically precise, not poetic — the great liturgies are sung at night, and the Drow are her first-favored children of the dark. Dawn services exist and are beloved, but every Zhuvedian knows in their bones which direction prayer faces after sundown: up.

THE PACKLAW: GENDER AND AUTHORITY

A pattern runs through the empire's seats of settled power that Zhuvedian doctrine names outright rather than leaving unremarked: Empress Nyreeza ruled in her own right, not as regent; Duchess Vasq, Voivode Morn, Matriarch Corvane, Saint-Regent Olvesa, Legate Thorne, and Mistress Shen hold their offices by the same unquestioned legitimacy a man would. The Church calls this the Packlaw — teaching that the Matron leads Her pack as the wisest wolf leads hers, by right of endurance and judgment rather than raw strength, and that a pack's survival runs through its mothers as often as its sires. It bars no man from rule — Qilvayas sits the Lupine Throne — but it means nobody in the Crownlands remarks on a woman holding a duchy, a see, or an empire, any more than a person in our world remarks on a man holding one. The Imperial Cult's doctrine that the ruling bloodline carries Zhuvedus's divine spark sits easily beside it: the spark passes through blood, not sex.

The doctrine runs strongest wherever authority is settled — thrones, duchies, sees, the machinery of a functioning institution — because settled authority is what the pack already recognizes. Authority still being fought for skews male throughout the fractured territories not by any law but by the same logic in reverse: a bastard never legitimized, a king awaiting a coronation not yet held, a raider refused a title four times, a warden whose authority his own Voivode has never sanctioned. A pack does not hand its trust to what hasn't yet proven it belongs. Once claimed and settled, the Packlaw would apply to these powers precisely as it does to the Crownlands — a detail their courts have not yet had cause to consider.

THE WOLF-SHAPE: LYCANTHROPY AND DOCTRINE

In an empire whose goddess wears the wolf, lycanthropy cannot be neutral — and is not. Church doctrine holds the wolf-shape taken by curse to be profanation, the Matron's image stolen and worn wrongly, and the Church hunts it with

grim formality (the wolf-trial is a recognized proceeding, with recognized abuses). Folk belief, older and quieter, holds that sometimes the shape is her mark — and that the difference is visible in what the changed one does under the moon. Between doctrine and folk belief runs the setting's built-in gothic engine: the falsely accused, the genuinely monstrous, and the rare, terrifying possibility of a true-marked one, about which the Church's files are sealed and the Old Observance says nothing at all, loudly.

MARRIAGE AS OATH, AND THE DENMOTHER'S CHOICE

A wedding vow is the single most common binding oath an ordinary Zhuvedian will ever speak, and it carries the same literal weight as any other. Marriage is sworn before a Church witness in the Crownlands and loyalist provinces, or at the standing stones in Tarnovar, consistent with Tarnovari oath-custom generally. An unrepaired infidelity or abandonment is not merely private sorrow — unhealed, it is a small, personal echo of Zhuvedus's own crime, whether or not either party has ever heard the founding myth. Divorce exists, and, consistent with how the empire treats broken oaths everywhere else, it is not a document but a counter-oath: a formal Release, requiring Church sanction and mutual consent, or, on proven grave breach, a magistrate or Church tribunal may grant it unilaterally. A marriage ended without Release carries the same taint as any other unrepaired vow; one ended properly carries none.

Titled succession follows the Packlaw's logic rather than strict primogeniture: a ruling parent formally names their heir by open declaration — the Denmother's Choice — revisable over the parent's lifetime, and it need not fall to the eldest, or even to a child by blood, in rare and dramatic cases. It is the naming that carries legal force, not the birth order. Duchess Vasq's court runs on this fact: with Aldous the elder, sickly, and Tavian the younger, ambitious, her succession is a live and unresolved question rather than a formality — which is precisely why the Garland needs to be as good as it is. Qilvayas himself has named no heir of either kind, a fact his court is certainly aware of and does not discuss above a whisper.

Regional variation is light but real. Tarnovar extends its existing custom — a dead Tarnovari's oaths, not their body, are what the living formally inherit, spoken at the standing stones by whoever takes up the unfinished promise — to leadership itself: a title passes to whoever takes up the stone, which is very often a named heir but does not have to be. The Suthmark times common inheritance to the harvest calendar, the same rhythm as its burials, so estates settle at a season's turn rather than the moment of death. Elsewhere, ordinary property is governed by local custom rather than fixed imperial law.

THE WILLING SHAPE: WILDSHAPE AND DOCTRINE

Wildshape is not lycanthropy, and Church doctrine — for once — agrees without much argument. A druid's wolf-shape is willed, self-possessed, and takes nothing from anyone; there is no theft of the Matron's image to punish, because nothing was stolen. The wolf-trial has no jurisdiction here, and no sanctioned Church court has ever convened one against a druid for the shape itself. Folk belief goes further and warmer than doctrine bothers to: in the provinces, and

especially where the Old Observance still runs strong, a druid who wears the wolf is read as walking proof of favor, and villages that would never touch a stray wolf for luck will happily touch the hem of a druid who has just changed back.

The Office of Omens, characteristically, finds a third position: not persecution, but paperwork. A Chartered practitioner's licensing file quietly notes wildshape capability the way it notes any other unusual talent, and a druid who takes wolf-shape often or publicly enough to be noticed can expect a polite, entirely non-threatening visit from someone with a ledger, asking careful questions about frequency, circumstance, and whether anything unusual happens under the moon. Nothing comes of it, usually. The Office simply likes to know where the Matron's shape is currently walking around — and reserves the right to be very interested indeed if it ever hears the word "unusual" twice about the same person.

THE WOLF-PRICE: BLOOD DEBTS AND THE PROVINCES

A wolf's death by human hand carries two separate reckonings, and only one of them is the law's. Imperial statute — reformed under Qilvayas to say plainly what older law only implied — recognizes self-defense as a full defense against a wolf-killing charge, provided the killing is reported to a magistrate within three days and the body produced or accounted for. Get that right, in a place with a magistrate worth the name, and the law is satisfied.

The law was never the whole of it. Older than any statute is the Wolf-Price — a debt owed not to the throne but to the wolf itself, or to whatever stands in for it: the nearest shrine-keeper, the local almonry, sometimes an old woman in a village with no shrine at all who has simply always been the one people pay. The price is small and never negotiable — coin, meat, a season's labor, whatever the keeper judges fits the death — and paying it has nothing to do with guilt or innocence. A traveler who kills a wolf defending a child pays exactly the same price as one who kills carelessly; the debt isn't about fault, it's about balance. What changes with the circumstances is reputation: pay the price promptly and the story that follows out of town is "they did right by it." Delay, argue, or leave before the shrine-keeper is satisfied, and the story that follows is worse than anything a magistrate could write down — and in places far enough from a garrison, the magistrate's paperwork was never going to be what protected you anyway.

THE CHOSEN BEAST: COMPANIONS AND THE BEFRIENDED

A wolf that chooses a person — a ranger's companion, a freed animal that stays, a pack that walks a traveler's road unbidden — is read across the empire as the Matron's visible favor, and it functions like minor rank: doors open, elders nod, clergy will bless the animal (and quietly take note of the person). Doctrine distinguishes sharply between the befriended and the tamed. A wolf that stays of its own will honors the Matron; a wolf collared, caged, leashed, or sold profanes her — a wolf-cage is scandal verging on sacrilege, and no honest market in the empire sells one. Feeding wild wolves is lawful and, at the empire's margins, encouraged (Orlath's pilgrim stations are the famous case); the custom everywhere else is superstitious care — you feed the pack at the treeline, and you never call them in.

Mechanically nothing changes — but the mapping matters: the Beast Master ranger is where core 5e grants a true permanent companion, and a Beast Master whose bond is a wolf is the standing, sacred-animal version of everything above — not a temporary shape but a lasting relationship with the Matron's own beast, which provincial villages read as being touched and capital institutions keep on file. Druids, by contrast, get no permanent companion in core rules; wildshape is the druid's entire animal relationship, and doctrine treats it accordingly (see The Willing Shape). Familiars and animal handling work as written. Socially, a visible wolf companion is standing — warmer reactions among the devout, harder scrutiny from the Office of Omens, exactly the wildshape grammar (a wolf-shaped familiar, being a spirit wearing her shape, is doctrinally fascinating and reliably file-worthy). DM only, and quietly load-bearing: wolves will not abide thin-written ground. A companion wolf is, functionally, a living Wardstone — it will balk at scarred places before any instrument reads them — and no befriended wolf, however loyal, will enter the Old Forum district. Its person will never know why. The DM will.

RELICS AND THE BLESSED ECONOMY (APPROVED FRAME)

Per the approved fork: arcane items are scarce and chartered, but relics and blessed items flow through the faith. The Church's almonies sell sanctioned mercy at honest prices — stamped healing potions brewed under the Sanction, holy water, blessed tapers — and the great relic-treasures hold the setting's serious magic: the femur of a saint inside a mace-head, a battle-standard that has never fallen, a reliquary that quiets fever in a room. Mechanically, relics are official magic items wearing provenance — a +1 mace is the Ferrule of Saint Oswenna, and the provenance is the point. The schism doubles everything: Orlath maintains a rival relic-treasury and disputes the authenticity of half the Sanctum's inventory, Rivergate runs a brisk trade in false relics (and, very occasionally, terrifyingly real ones with forged papers), and the Office of Omens polices the whole mess. Player-facing consequence: healing is purchasable and human-scaled; wonder is rare, holy, and always has a story attached.

PEOPLES OF THE EMPIRE

The empire is human-majority — right for its Byzantine texture — with the other peoples distributed where history put them. Distribution below; regional detail in Part V.

The Founder's Blood (Drow): Zhuvedus was Drow — the Matron's chosen, first-favored child of her night — and the imperial dynasty is his surviving line. Threnvos was Drow as well (approved): twin champions of the same goddess, the same blood, one throne. There is no Underdark and no spider-cult in this world; Drow are simply the old blood of the founding, and they are nearly gone — a scattering of ancient noble houses claiming distant dynastic kinship, and the throne itself. The founder's people dwindling to a single family on a single chair is the campaign's decline theme in miniature. A Drow character outside the dynasty is therefore an enormous statement (Session Zero's existing note, now with teeth): they will be read as dynastic kin, dynastic claimant, or something nobody has words for. DELIBERATELY OPEN: whether any line of Threnvos survives. If it does, it is Drow, it is rightful-claimant material

of the highest order, and it should not be spent early — same handling class as the Tarnovar revelation.

Humans: The overwhelming majority everywhere, in named regional cultures: Zhuvedians (Crownlands core), Ostfolk, Suthfolk, Tarnovari, Brekelanders, Velmarenes, Orlathines, Ardvenners, the Skell, Normerines. Human cultural texture per region in Part V.

Dwarves: The Stonesworn of Tarnovar's highlands — the stone-oath culture and dwarven nature are a natural marriage, and roughly a third of Tarnovar is dwarven, fully Tarnovari in identity. Smaller populations: the Suthmark's eastern hills (including the villages around Greywell, which is part of why the missing girls stay missing — hill-dwarf families have learned the valley's law does not climb), Normere's hired stonewrights, and the capital's masons' guild. Archivist Vell is a hill dwarf (which quietly explains a career that has outlasted four chancellors).

Elves: Wood elves keep to the deep forests — Tarnovar's Old Wood and the Ardven wilds — as the long-remembered folk of the Old Observance; canon-safe on the founding secret (2,000 years exceeds any living memory), but elven ballad-memory reaches closer to the fracture than human record does, which makes old elves valuable and dangerous listeners. High elf blood persists in a handful of faded Crownlands houses — more portraits than people now. Half-elves are the empire's courtier class (Chancellor Sorral, canon) and Velmareth's natural children.

Half-Orcs: Legion stock — respected veteran families of the Ostmark marches, descendants of frontier auxiliaries who earned the rolls the hard way. Brune Halloc of the Inkhands is one of Rivergate's. No orc 'menace' exists in this setting; the marches' old auxiliary peoples were absorbed, not fought.

Halflings: The river-trade people — Coppergate's copyists and landlords, the Ostrun barge families, Velmareth's middle guilds. Comfortable, networked, and collectively the best-informed civilians in the empire.

Gnomes: The House of the Craft's natural constituency — instrument-makers, ward-wrights, archival engineers. Tirell Mosse, dealer in defunct authorities, is a rock gnome (of course he is).

Tieflings — the Marked: In a world of covenant-metaphysics, tieflings are what an ancestor's bad bargain looks like three generations later: bloodlines carrying a covenant made flesh. Feared in Church lands, filed by the Office, tolerated in Velmareth and Rivergate where everything is tolerated at the right rate. A Marked character's line-covenant is a ready-made personal hook — and, handled with sign-off, one such line could eventually trace somewhere campaign-relevant.

Dragonborn — the Sarkanni: Rare famous foreigners: mercenary companies from across the southern sea, known by reputation (superb, expensive, contract-scrupulous — a Sarkanni company has never broken terms in living memory, which in THIS setting is remarkable and remarked upon). Available for PCs; minimal footprint otherwise.

The Wolves: Sacred empire-wide. Killing a wolf is terrible luck, worse law, and — in the provinces — grounds for the kind of trouble that magistrates decline to interrupt. Wolves are omen-bearers: their behavior is read the way other cultures read birds. (The DM knows the wolves of Aenodira

have been leaving the Old Forum district, one family at a time, for three years.)

THE FOUNDING MYTH: ZHUVEDUS AND THE BROKEN OATH

THREE ACCOUNTS OF THE FOUNDER

No single account of Zhuvedus's nature is universally accepted. Three distinct traditions coexist, each serving different interests, and each believing itself the truth.

Church Doctrine (Public): The Church of the Lupine Matron teaches that Zhuvedus was a mortal hero, chosen and favored by the Matron but never divine himself—virtuous in his triumphs, flawed in his failures, and mortal in his death. To the Church, only the Matron is properly divine; elevating any mortal, however great, to godhood would be heretical. “Sinful children of Zhuvedus” is meant in this light: heirs to a great but flawed man, not to a god.

The Imperial Cult (Public): A smaller, older priesthood tied to the imperial household teaches otherwise—that Zhuvedus was elevated to divine or semi-divine status upon his death, and that the ruling bloodline carries a literal spark of his apotheosis. This doctrine underwrites the throne's claim to hereditary legitimacy: only Zhuvedus's line, in this telling, has the right to rule. The Church tolerates this cult's existence because confronting it directly would mean confronting the throne itself.

The Buried Truth (Hidden): A far older, deliberately suppressed tradition holds a darker and more specific account—that Zhuvedus was not the Matron's only champion in his own era, that his rise involved the destruction of a rival she had also favored, and that his triumph came at the cost of a sacred oath broken in her own witness. This is the account developed below. It survives only in fragments: old ballads the Church has worked for generations to lose, half-remembered oral traditions in the further provinces, and the private knowledge of a very few people still living—among them, Vaelindra.

THRENVOS AND THE SWORN COVENANT

Long before the empire existed in anything like its current form, the Matron favored more than one champion in a single generation. Alongside Zhuvedus stood Threnvos, leader of a different people with an equal claim to her blessing. Rather than see one destroy the other, she is said to have bound them under a sworn covenant—witnessed and sanctified by her own power—some form of joint rule, mutual restraint, or shared founding. The exact terms are lost. What survives is only that it was sacred, that both men swore it freely, and that it was meant to hold.

Zhuvedus broke it. He destroyed Threnvos and claimed sole right to found what became the empire, and he did it under the eyes of the god who had sanctified the promise between them.

THE OATHBREAKER'S CROWN

Zhuvedus was, by the account preserved in the buried tradition, a paladin—sworn to the Oath of Devotion, a champion whose given word was meant to be inviolable. Breaking a sacred oath sworn before a god does not simply end quietly; it corrupts. In shattering his covenant with Threnvos, Zhuvedus fell from his oath and rose again as something else—an Oathbreaker, drawing on darker power in the same moment he used it to destroy his rival and seize the founding of the empire alone.

This is, perhaps, the empire's deepest and most carefully guarded irony: the throne whose current occupant is rewriting the Golden Tablets in pursuit of lawful restoration was founded by a broken oath, and the man who broke it drew the very power of his triumph from that betrayal. Neither the Church nor the imperial cult preserves this detail—both have every reason not to. A paladin or cleric with sufficient insight standing in the right place, however, might still recognize the particular wrongness of Oathbreaker corruption for what it is.

THE SHADOW'S ORIGIN (DM ONLY)

Threnvos did not simply die. Whatever he felt in that final moment—betrayal, rage, the specific grief of being killed by a man he'd trusted enough to swear brotherhood with—did not dissipate with him. It became the seed around which the wound left by the broken oath took shape. What waits in the vision's storm clouds is not a two-thousand-year-old grudge, and it is not a mindless force of pure entropy—it is both, fused together at the moment of its birth. The personal grievance gave the impersonal hunger a shape and a direction; the impersonal hunger has kept the personal grievance fed and growing long after any ordinary vengeful spirit would have faded.

That fusion is what makes the entity dangerous in the present tense. Every oath broken since—every noble house that abandoned fealty, every treaty a warlord tore up, every governor who quietly stopped honoring the crown—has fed something that already had a will and a memory attached to it. It has been growing more itself, not just larger, for two centuries of imperial fracture. This gives player and NPC choices around loyalty, betrayal, and broken promises a direct, if invisible, bearing on the threat shown in the opening vision—a mechanism the DM can use quietly throughout the campaign without ever stating it outright to the players.

The binding site—where the oath was broken and Threnvos died—lies beneath the imperial capital itself, beneath the Old Forum (confirmed; see Geography and Locations), which explains why the vision shows that specific city burning rather than some other place of significance. This ties the site's development directly to the capital's geography (see Geography and Locations) and gives Empress Nyreeza's disappearance a concrete shape: she was very likely searching for evidence of this true founding account, and quite possibly found the site itself.

THE TURNING AWAY (DM ONLY)

The founding was witnessed. Several hundred people stood in the Witness Hall beneath what is now the Old Forum to see Zhuvedus and Threnvos swear the covenant that would make an empire—and when Zhuvedus broke it, the assembly turned away in unison. In this world's metaphysics that is not cowardice but mechanism: oaths

bind because they are witnessed, which is why the Tarnovari swear on stone before their kin, why marriage requires a Church witness, and why Duke Norr has every landholder swear before the assembled hall. When the assembly refused to see, they unwitnessed the covenant, and the unbinding is what made the betrayal possible rather than merely unpunished. Zhuvedus struck the blow. The witnesses made it a founding.

Two consequences follow, and they govern the campaign. First, the shadow does not feed only on broken oaths but on the silence around them — every institutional look-away in the empire is the same act as the Hall, from a duchess letting a false record stand to a chancellor who asks exactly one question and never a second. Second, witnessing starves it, and the Vigil is the counter-rite: watched, lit, never left alone, owed to the dead as dead and not as the good. The Vigil is penance. It was instituted by the witnesses or their children as an apology none of their descendants remember making, which is why it is the one practice that survives unchanged across every schism in the empire.

The Golden Tablets were composed by the witnesses. The empire's sacred founding law is the self-exoneration document of the people who looked away — which is precisely what Empress Nyreeza meant when she wrote that the wound predates the Wall and the Tablets were written over it. The law was the cover-up, written first. Emperor Qilvayas is rewriting the Tablets now, and a legal code that makes oaths enforceable, witnessed, and recorded is, in this metaphysics, a starvation regimen against the thing beneath his city. He has built the only real weapon by institutional instinct, without any idea what he is doing. His Daily Draw — the habit his clerks find inefficient — is the Emperor personally witnessing one citizen a day, and it is the most important thing he does.

THE SCOURING, AND EMPEROR VASKAREN (DM ONLY)

Roughly two hundred years ago, as the fracture began, Emperor Vaskaren the Restorer went looking for why his empire was failing. He found the Witness Hall, and he had it erased — methodically, professionally, by masons working for weeks under a commission paid from the imperial purse with its purpose left blank. The second crime is the same crime: an act of un-witnessing performed by the one family the founding had made. Vaskaren's restoration failed. Qilvayas is the second restorer of that line, and does not know whether he is repeating the pattern or breaking it.

The scourers missed one section, forty feet up on the eastern gallery's highest tier, where a man on a scaffold worked alone at the end of a long day. Two spans of frieze survive: dozens of faces carved with the particularity of portraiture, house-sigils worked into collars, every one of them turned away in the same instant with the composure of people who have decided together and without a word to see nothing. Several of those houses hold seats at court today. Vaskaren's order survives in the dynastic archive; it is how Nyreeza found the way down, and it is what waits, unopened, in her sealed dispatch case.

THE UNKEPT VIGIL (DM ONLY)

Threnvos was killed by his sworn brother under the Matron's own witness and buried under a wall, under a forum, under a founding myth — with no Vigil, no watching,

no light, and nobody to see him home. The wound beneath Aenodira is an unkept vigil two thousand years long. The entity has two fused components: Threnvos's grief, which is a person and can be laid to rest, and the impersonal hunger the broken covenant unleashed, which is neither. Keeping the Vigil separates them — a real victory and not the victory. The grief goes quiet because it was the only part a funeral could touch; what remains does not grieve, does not remember, and cannot be reasoned with, because the part that could have been reasoned with is the part laid to rest.

This is the campaign's pivot from a dungeon problem to a civilization problem. What remains is fed by every broken word and every averted eye in the fractured empire, and it will keep eating as long as that continues. There is no monster to kill at the bottom of the hole. There is a civilization to fix — which makes the Zhuvedian Laws the actual weapon and the Grey-Gold Rising considerably more than a set piece. On the Matron: she may be down there, and may always have been, keeping the vigil nobody else would. Divine magic functions normally in the deep reach and clerics who pray receive, but there is never a form, never a voice, and never a confirmation. The ambiguity is permanent and deliberate.

EMPEROR QILVAYAS AND THE LUPINE THRONE

THE YOUNG EMPEROR

Qilvayas is a 110-year-old Drow—young by the standards of his long-lived race, but old enough to rule without a regent. He ascended to the Lupine Throne following the mysterious disappearance of his mother, Empress Nyreeza. Raised within the imperial palace, he received the finest education available in history, law, military strategy, theology, and statecraft. More importantly, he studied the empire's decline intimately, tracing its causes and contemplating solutions.

His youth gives him energy and idealism, but also makes him somewhat untested. He has never commanded armies in the field, never navigated the brutal realities of imperial politics at the highest level, and never faced the compromises that restoring an empire might demand. His vision is clear, his ambition genuine, and his belief in the righteousness of his cause unshakeable—but the question remains whether he can adapt that vision to reality without losing himself in the process.

THE MAN BEHIND THE CROWN

In person, Qilvayas is precise, courteous, and quietly relentless. He speaks softly and in the cadences of law — clauses, provisos, careful definitions — and he never raises his voice, having learned early that an emperor who shouts has already lost the room. He works brutal hours, sleeps little even by Drow standards, and keeps three habits his court has learned to read: he walks the Long Course alone at dawn twice a week (guarded at a distance, to the Palatine Guard's despair); he answers petitions from commoners personally, one each day, chosen at random from the pile (his clerks call it the Daily Draw and privately think it inefficient; he considers it the point); and he has never, in three years, entered his mother's study. It is cleaned weekly, by his order. Nothing in it may be moved.

His grief for his mother is real, unresolved, and armored over with work. Known to almost no one: among Nyreeza's effects is a sealed dispatch case, her personal cipher on the lock, which Qilvayas has never opened — officially because the succession inventory has not reached it, actually because he is afraid of what it contains. It sits in the sealed study. If the party ever earns his trust deeply enough, or forces the issue, the case is a campaign-scale revelation waiting in a locked room.

THE COURT

Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin: Gatekeeper of access (see Geography and Locations, Highcourt). Serves the office more than the man; served Nyreeza first, and his opinion of how the son compares to the mother is a thing he has never once expressed, which everyone finds more unnerving than any stated view.

Archjurist Senna Vhal: Head of the Law Commission drafting the Zhuvedian Laws — brilliant, exhausted, and the person who actually holds the pen on the empire's new foundation. She fights a running quiet battle with Kessin over access to the Emperor and a louder one with the provinces over every clause. If the restoration has a second-most-important person, it is her, and she knows exactly how expendable that makes her.

Legate Bruvasca Thorne: Commander of the Palatine Guard (see Geography and Locations, the Garrison) — and, by any honest reckoning, the finest field commander the throne possesses. Her name was made at the Ashline, where she broke a Skellvard raid with eight hundred men against five times that number; the soldiers' songs about it are the closest thing the modern legions have to a victory anyone remembers. That is precisely her problem. The court needs her, the legions love her, and the throne can never quite decide whether her loyalty is a fact or a fortune it has not yet had to spend. She has been given every duty except the one she was made for: an army large enough to actually reconquer something. Her husband Bram, a retired quartermaster who manages her correspondence and is widely underestimated, keeps a private ledger of every promise the court has made her and quietly amends it after every audience. See The Powers of the Fractured Empire for her expanded profile and threads.

Mistress Averil Shen: Keeper of what is formally the Bureau of Correspondence and functionally the throne's intelligence service — small, underfunded, and run on Shen's personal network of clerks, couriers, and debts. She was Nyreeza's creature before she was Qilvayas's, and she is the only member of the court who conducted her own private inquiry into the Empress's disappearance. What she found, or failed to find, is hers to reveal.

Hierophant Malzeth Corr: Head of the imperial cult (see The Keepers of the Ascent). Present at court for every rite and most councils; influential in exact proportion to how much the throne needs its divinity that season.

THE VISION OF RESTORATION

Qilvayas's plan for imperial restoration rests on several pillars:

Legal Reform: He seeks to rewrite the Golden Tablets, creating a new comprehensive legal code—the “Zhuvedian Laws”—that will modernize governance, eliminate corruption,

and provide a unifying framework for all imperial territories. In his own words, these laws will be “forged by the fires of justice and cast in molds of wisdom.” This echoes the historical Corpus Juris Civilis of Emperor Justinian—the belief that law itself can be a civilizing and unifying force.

Administrative Revival: He is rebuilding imperial institutions that have atrophied or disappeared. The Imperial Academy is a key part of this effort, training a new generation of loyal, competent administrators who understand his vision.

Diplomatic Reunification: Where possible, Qilvayas prefers to bring fractured territories back into the fold through negotiation, offering stability, legal protection, and the prestige of the empire in exchange for renewed loyalty.

Military Force When Necessary: While he prefers peaceful methods, Qilvayas is prepared to use force against those who threaten imperial stability or refuse reasonable terms. He understands that some warlords and breakaway states will never willingly submit.

The question the campaign will explore is whether these idealistic goals can survive contact with reality—and what Qilvayas might become in the pursuit of restoration.

That question has a mythic precedent he likely doesn't know he's repeating. The empire's own founder broke a sacred oath in pursuit of a goal he believed justified it, and became something else in the process (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath). Every pragmatic compromise Qilvayas makes in the name of restoration—every ally set aside, every promise expedient to break—walks the same road his ancestor walked to its end. Whether he ever recognizes the echo is one of the campaign's central open questions.

LAW, OATH, AND BOUND LABOR

A reforming Emperor modeling himself on the historical architect of the Corpus Juris Civilis inherits that architect's hardest question along with his ambition: what does the empire's law actually say about a person's claim on another person's labor? Zhuvedian law has a clean, old answer for the worst of it — chattel slavery is illegal and doctrinally blasphemous throughout the empire, and has been for centuries, on grounds that grow directly from the oath-magic itself: if a sworn word binds because the speaker's will is real, then owning a person outright, denying they possess a will capable of being bound, is theologically incoherent. The capacity to swear is the proof of personhood; the law does not entertain owning what can vow.

Beneath that clean line sit three legal categories the coming Zhuvedian Laws will have to reconcile with each other. Oath-bound service — Duke Norr's entire system in Normere — is fully legal: a subject swears personal service directly, and the oath is real and binding because it was freely spoken, regardless of how much pressure made ‘freely’ a technicality. Debt-bondage and indenture are legal, regulated, and time-limited — an ordinary remedy for debt or minor infraction, bounded by contract, ending when the contract says it ends. Hostage-diplomacy, the Academy's own admission practice among them, is a wholly separate category and not bondage at all: a diplomatic guarantee between powers in which the hostage retains full legal personhood and is owed treatment as an honored, if constrained, guest — a standard high enough to explain the

practice's respectability and loose enough that individual cases can still go quietly wrong.

The empire's actual crisis is not its law but its reach. Imperial statute forbids chattel slavery everywhere; imperial statute has not reached everywhere in two hundred years. In the Brekelands, where warlord companies are, in plain terms, little better than bandits with armies, that gap is where the law's clean answer stops being an abstraction and starts being an atrocity nobody enforces against. It is, in the most literal sense available, exactly what Qilvayas's restoration is for.

THE MYSTERY OF EMPRESS NYREEZA

Qilvayas's mother, Empress Nyreeza, disappeared under circumstances that remain unclear. She was the one who began revitalizing the Imperial Academy and took the first steps toward institutional reform. Her sudden absence created a power vacuum that Qilvayas filled, but it also left questions: Was her disappearance natural, political, or something more sinister? Did she flee, was she taken, or is she dead? Does Qilvayas know more than he admits?

Her fate remains a thread that can be pulled as the campaign develops—potentially revealing allies, enemies, conspiracies, or truths about the empire itself. One known thread already exists: the Seeress Vaelindra of the Still Waters was among the last people to meet with the Empress before her disappearance, and she has never spoken of what passed between them (see Key NPCs and Factions).

The working theory (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvodus and the Broken Oath) is that she was searching for evidence of the empire's true founding account, and quite possibly found the site where it happened. Whether that discovery left her dead, transformed, or simply trapped somewhere no one has thought to look is still undecided, and can remain a genuine mystery the party uncovers through play.

THE IMPERIAL ACADEMY OF THE LUPINE THRONE

PURPOSE AND HISTORY

The Imperial Academy was originally founded during the empire's golden age to train the administrators, officers, and specialists needed to govern and defend such a vast realm. Like much else, it fell into decline as the empire fractured—many regional academies closed, curricula degraded, and standards slipped.

Empress Nyreeza began the academy's revival in the years before her disappearance, recognizing that rebuilding imperial institutions required trained personnel. Emperor Qilvayas has continued and expanded this effort, seeing the academy as essential to his restoration plans. He needs loyal, competent people who understand his vision and can implement his reforms across the empire.

Today, multiple Imperial Academies exist across territories that still recognize the throne, but the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne in the capital remains the most prestigious. Studying at the capital academy means access to the best instructors, the imperial library and archives, proximity to power, and the possibility of advancement in

imperial service. Graduation from the capital academy opens doors that provincial schools cannot match.

ADMISSION AND STUDENT BODY

The empire maintains a policy of universal education—in theory, any subject can seek admission to an Imperial Academy. In practice, admission to the capital academy operates through a lottery system that is less fair than it appears:

The Official Process: Applicants from across the empire enter their names into an annual lottery for admission. The system is designed to give opportunity to talented individuals regardless of birth or wealth.

The Reality: Wealthy families make generous “donations” to the academy, and their children mysteriously get selected. Local lords ensure their favored protégés gain admission. Some slots are reserved for hostage-diplomacy situations—sons and daughters of border lords and ambitious nobles kept close to ensure good behavior. But enough legitimate lottery winners make it through that the system maintains its legitimacy and the student body remains genuinely diverse.

This creates a fascinating mix: children of privilege alongside scholarship students who earned their place, hostages resentful of being pawns alongside true believers in the empire, ambitious commoners seeking advancement alongside nobility maintaining family traditions. The academy deliberately fosters this diversity, believing that future imperial servants need to understand and work with people from all backgrounds.

THE THREE HOUSES

The Imperial Academy is organized into three houses, each focusing on different areas of study necessary for imperial service. Students affiliate with a primary house based on their chosen career path but regularly cross-train in the other houses as their profession requires.

HOUSE OF THE SWORD

The House of the Sword trains officers, strategists, and those who will serve in martial or military capacities. The curriculum emphasizes not just combat skills but the art of leading, organizing, and sustaining military forces.

Core Studies: Military tactics and strategy, logistics and supply chain management, leadership and command, military history and analysis of historical campaigns, fortification and siege warfare, cavalry and infantry doctrine, naval operations (where relevant).

Practical Training: Physical conditioning, weapons training, small unit tactics, command exercises with actual troops, war games and simulations.

Typical Career Paths: Imperial legion officers, garrison commanders, military advisors to provincial governors, personal guards to nobility, mercenary company leaders, military engineers (with Craft cross-training), battlefield chaplains (with Seal cross-training).

HOUSE OF THE SEAL

The House of the Seal focuses on administration, law, theology, and governance—the civilian machinery that keeps an empire functioning. These students will become the

magistrates, tax collectors, diplomats, and priests who actually run imperial territories day-to-day.

Core Studies: Imperial law and the Zhuvedian legal codes, theology and doctrine of the Lupine Matron, rhetoric and persuasion, diplomacy and negotiation, taxation and fiscal policy, record-keeping and bureaucratic procedure, history and philosophy of governance.

Practical Training: Mock trials and legal proceedings, diplomatic simulations, public speaking and debate, religious ceremonies and rituals, administrative case studies.

Typical Career Paths: Magistrates and judges, imperial bureaucrats and administrators, tax collectors and treasury officials, diplomats and ambassadors, priests and religious officials, legal scholars, court advisors, intelligence officers (with Craft cross-training).

HOUSE OF THE CRAFT

The House of the Craft is the most diverse and internally varied, encompassing anyone whose skills serve the empire but don't fit neatly into military command or civil administration. The unifying principle is practical application—these are people who make things, solve problems, and get specialized work done.

Core Studies (varies by specialization): Engineering and architecture, medicine and surgery, alchemy and herbalism, cartography and surveying, languages and linguistics, codes and ciphers, arcane theory and spellcraft, artifice and magical item creation, trade and economics, arts and propaganda.

The Role of Magic: Most arcane and divine casters at the academy study in House of the Craft, as magic is treated as another specialized skill to be mastered and applied. Wizards study spellcraft and magical theory, clerics and paladins study theology (though they may take courses in the Seal as well), druids study natural philosophy, and artificers combine magical and mundane engineering.

Practical Training: Hands-on projects relevant to specialization, apprenticeships with master craftsmen or mages, field exercises applying skills in real situations.

Typical Career Paths: Imperial engineers and architects, court physicians and healers, alchemists and apothecaries, cartographers and explorers, spies and intelligence operatives, war wizards (with Sword cross-training), trade negotiators, artists and cultural ambassadors, artificers and enchanters.

CLASS PLACEMENT BY HOUSE

For character creation purposes, the thirteen base classes align with the houses as follows. Primary house reflects the class's core training; nearly every character concept will involve cross-training.

House of the Sword: Barbarian, Fighter, Monk. Paladins may choose Sword as primary if their concept is a warrior shaped by faith rather than a religious figure trained for war.

House of the Seal: Paladins who see themselves foremost as religious champions—think warrior-clergy in the Byzantine mold—may take Seal as primary with heavy Sword cross-training. Clerics with a doctrinal or pastoral focus may also justify Seal primary.

House of the Craft: Artificer, Bard (arts and propaganda), Cleric (divine magic, with substantial Seal cross-training in theology), Druid (natural philosophy), Ranger (wilderness operations), Rogue (espionage, codes, intelligence), Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard.

The imbalance toward Craft is intentional—it is explicitly the catch-all house for specialists, and magic is institutionally treated as a specialized skill rather than a separate estate. Players should choose primary house based on character concept, with the paladin placement left deliberately flexible.

CROSS-TRAINING AND CURRICULUM STRUCTURE

The academy's philosophy emphasizes cooperation between houses. The empire needs soldiers who understand law, administrators who respect military realities, and specialists who can work with both. To this end, cross-training is common and often required:

A military supply officer studies primarily in the Sword (logistics, military operations) but takes extensive coursework in the Seal (procurement law, contracts) and Craft (engineering, trade).

A battlefield medic is primarily Craft (medicine) with Sword secondary (understanding military operations, triage under fire).

A combat engineer focuses on Craft (engineering, fortifications) with Sword training (siege warfare, military architecture).

An intelligence officer might be Craft primary (espionage, languages, codes) with courses in both Seal (diplomacy, law) and Sword (military intelligence).

A military chaplain studies Seal (theology, law) with Sword coursework (military hierarchy, morale, battlefield ministry).

This flexibility allows the academy to train highly specialized professionals while ensuring they can work effectively across disciplines—crucial for serving a complex empire.

DORMITORIES AND SOCIAL STRUCTURE

Rather than segregating students by house, the academy deliberately assigns them to mixed residential halls based on year and cohort. This ensures that students from all three houses live, eat, and socialize together, breaking down professional silos and building the kind of cross-disciplinary relationships that effective imperial service requires.

Dormitory Facilities: Each residential hall includes communal dining areas, study rooms and libraries, courtyards for exercise and sparring, small shrines to the Lupine Matron, common rooms for socializing and recreation.

Social Dynamics: The dormitories are where lasting friendships form, where rivalries develop, and where students learn to see beyond house loyalties. Study groups mix houses, athletic competitions pit house against house for prestige, and social networks cross professional boundaries.

Despite official encouragement of cooperation, house pride remains strong. Informal competitions, debates over which house is most essential to the empire, and good-natured (and sometimes not-so-good-natured) rivalries are part of academy culture.

PROGRAM DURATION AND FIELD

EXERCISES

The standard academy program lasts four years. Students typically enter around age 18-20 (human equivalent) and graduate in their early twenties, ready to begin imperial service or pursue other paths.

First and Second Years: Foundation coursework in primary house, introduction to cross-training, basic practical skills, intensive study and classroom work.

Third Year: Advanced specialized study, deeper cross-training, more complex projects and simulations, beginning of practical application.

Fourth Year (Final Year): Students complete supervised field exercises—real-world assignments that prove they can apply their training outside the safety of the academy. These might include serving with imperial legions on patrol, assisting magistrates in provincial courts, conducting surveys or diplomatic missions, solving problems for local authorities, or taking on adventuring contracts that serve imperial interests.

Field exercises serve multiple purposes: they test competence under real conditions, build confidence and practical skills, create opportunities for students to distinguish themselves, and provide the empire with useful work from advanced students at minimal cost. Students often work in small mixed-house teams during these exercises, mirroring how they might operate in actual imperial service.

POST-GRADUATION EXPECTATIONS

All subjects of the empire are expected to serve, though the definition of “service” is deliberately vague and enforcement uneven in the fractured realm:

Direct Imperial Service: Accepting commissions as officers, magistrates, engineers, or other official imperial positions. This is what the academy ideally produces.

Regional Service: Returning home to serve local lords or territorial governments, technically fulfilling the service requirement without necessarily strengthening the central throne.

Guild and Civic Service: Joining craftsmen’s guilds, merchant associations, or other civic organizations that serve “the empire” in an abstract sense.

Independent Operations: Striking out as adventurers, mercenaries, merchants, or specialists, often rationalizing that protecting imperial citizens and interests counts as service.

Ignoring the Obligation: Some graduates simply pursue their own interests with no pretense of service, betting correctly that the weakened empire can’t enforce compliance everywhere.

The academy cannot and does not force specific career paths. Graduates make their own choices, though those who openly flout their obligations may find doors closed if they later seek imperial favor or positions.

THE PROVING (DM ONLY)

The capital academy maintains one tradition no student is ever told about: the Proving, a staged final examination administered irregularly, and only to cohorts the faculty judge exceptional. The chosen cohort receives what appears to be a genuine, dangerous commission — and completes it inside a controlled environment they believe is real, observed throughout by the faculty. The academy’s reasoning is coldly sound: an examination a student knows is an examination measures preparation; only a test mistaken for reality measures judgment, mercy, leadership, and nerve. Graduates who pass are told at the conclusion, sworn to secrecy about the method, and marked in sealed records as Proven — a designation certain offices in Highcourt know to look for. The party’s Proving is the subject of Sessions Three and Four (see the session module The Proving Below). The thematic rhyme — a benevolent institution deceiving its own for reasons it believes justify the deception, inside an empire founded on exactly that logic — is deliberate, and should never be stated aloud at the table. Let it sit.

THE PLAYER CHARACTERS

WHO THEY ARE

The player characters are final-year students at the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, currently completing their field exercises. They come from diverse backgrounds—some from loyal imperial territories, others from breakaway regions or neutral ground. Some earned their admission through the lottery, others through family influence or political arrangement. They may have different primary houses and specializations, but their time together at the academy—sharing dormitories, working on cross-training projects, competing in house competitions—has forged them into a cohesive unit.

They are competent but not yet famous—skilled enough to handle dangerous situations but still learning, still making mistakes, still figuring out who they are and what they believe. They represent the future Emperor Qilvayas is trying to build: capable, educated individuals who understand both the ideals of the empire and the messy reality of the fractured world.

THEIR PLANS

The party has decided that after graduation, they will form their own adventuring company—a mercenary band operating under the principle that “a job is a job and coin is coin.” This represents a choice to be masters of their own fate rather than following predetermined paths into imperial bureaucracy, military service, or guild positions.

Their academy training makes them uniquely qualified for this work. They can handle diverse challenges—combat, negotiation, investigation, problem-solving—and their cross-training means they work together seamlessly despite different specializations. In the chaos of the fractured empire, there’s always work for capable people willing to take on dangerous jobs that “decent folk may not wish to risk themselves to do.”

They might rationalize this as serving imperial interests (protecting imperial citizens, maintaining order, gathering intelligence) or simply be honest that they prefer freedom

and profit over institutional service. Either way, they're planning to strike out independently once they complete their final exercises and officially graduate.

But fate—or the gods, or something else—has other plans for them.

THE INCITING INCIDENT: THE SHARED VISION

THE VISION ITSELF

After completing their latest field exercise and celebrating with the profits from their client, the party retires to their inn for the night. During sleep, each character receives the same vision—or perhaps nightmare:

Dark storm clouds gather over the imperial capital. The city below burns with infernal flames—not natural fire, but something wrong, something that shouldn't exist in the mortal world. The characters are present in the vision but powerless, unable to move or speak, only able to witness in horror.

Their gaze is drawn upward to the storm clouds. Behind the roiling darkness lurks an immense shadow—not just large, but vast, world-shaking, wrong. It emanates a roar that resonates in their bones, that speaks of ancient power and terrible purpose. The characters cannot scream, cannot flee, cannot do anything but watch until the vision fades to blackness and they awaken drenched in sweat.

When they compare notes, they realize with growing unease that they all experienced exactly the same vision, down to the smallest details. This is no ordinary dream.

THE RESPONSE

Despite their academy training, the party has no frame of reference for this. Shared prophetic visions aren't part of the curriculum. But they know someone who might have answers: quiet word among academy scholars and capital contacts speaks of a Seeress in the city—a woman named Vaelindra, once of the Church, now independent—who is consulted discreetly by people of consequence when omens defy explanation. She is not advertised; she is referred. Finding her is the party's first step.

The vision has marked them. Whether they want it or not, they are now connected to something larger than their plans for an independent mercenary company. The capital calls, and with it, their destiny.

They must travel to the capital—back to the heart of the empire they thought they'd left behind—and seek answers from the Seeress. What they learn there will determine not just their own futures, but perhaps the fate of the Empire of Zhuvedus itself.

CAMPAIGN THEMES AND POTENTIAL DIRECTIONS

CORE THEMES

The Qilvayas Symphony explores several interconnected themes:

Legacy and Restoration: Can past glory be reclaimed? Should it be? What is lost in the attempt to restore what was?

Idealism vs. Reality: The tension between Qilvayas's noble vision and the compromises that achieving it might require. When does pragmatism become corruption? When does necessary force become tyranny?

Prophecy and Free Will: The party has seen a potential future. Can it be changed? Should it be? Are they agents of destiny or masters of their own fate?

Unity vs. Freedom: Is imperial reunification worth the cost to those who have built new lives in the fractured territories? Does order justify the loss of autonomy?

Power and Its Corruption: What happens when good intentions meet the brutal realities of power? How do individuals and institutions change when pursuing righteous goals through questionable means?

POSSIBLE INTERPRETATIONS OF THE VISION

The shadow creature in the vision can be developed in several directions, depending on the tone and focus of the campaign:

The Empire's Dark Reflection: The shadow represents what the empire becomes if Qilvayas's methods grow too brutal. The infernal flames are purges and forced compliance. The vision is a warning about the cost of restoration—showing the party what they might need to prevent or oppose.

Ancient Power Unleashed: The Lupine Throne or some imperial regalia contains a bound entity or dark pact from the empire's founding. Qilvayas, desperate to save the empire, might reach for this power without understanding the consequences. The vision shows the result of that choice.

External Existential Threat: The shadow is real, literal, and coming—an ancient enemy, a planar incursion, or something awakening. Only a unified empire has any chance of surviving, justifying Qilvayas's urgency but also forcing terrible choices about how quickly reunification must happen.

Theological Crisis: The shadow represents corruption spreading through the faith of the Lupine Matron—heresy, false prophets, or something masquerading as divine will. The vision warns of spiritual catastrophe that could destroy the empire from within.

Combination or Misdirection: The truth might combine elements from multiple interpretations, or the vision itself

might be incomplete or intentionally misleading, sent by forces with their own agendas.

Working answer for DM reference: the shadow is a fusion of the personal and the impersonal—Threnvos's dying essence bound to the force unleashed by Zhuvedus's broken oath, fed since by every betrayal the fractured empire has produced. See *The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath* for the full account. This should not be revealed to players outright; let them arrive at pieces of it through Vaelindra, Nyreeza's trail, and whatever they eventually find beneath the capital.

POTENTIAL CAMPAIGN ARCS

The campaign can develop in various directions based on player choices and interests:

Agents of the Empire: The party works with (or for) Qilvayas, helping implement his reforms, dealing with threats to reunification, and navigating the moral complexities of restoration. They become key players in imperial politics.

Independent Investigators: The party pursues their original plan of independence but finds themselves repeatedly drawn into events connected to the vision. They operate in the spaces between factions, making their own choices about which side to support in any given situation.

Opposition to Empire: If Qilvayas's methods become tyrannical or the vision reveals dark truths about imperial restoration, the party might actively work against reunification, supporting breakaway territories or seeking alternative solutions.

Preventing Catastrophe: If the shadow represents an actual external or supernatural threat, the party might focus on investigating and preventing the catastrophe shown in their vision, regardless of political implications.

The campaign's tone allows for moral complexity—there may be no clear “right” answer to whether the empire should be restored, what methods are justified, or even whether the vision's warning can or should be heeded. The party will need to make difficult choices with imperfect information, and their decisions will have real consequences for the empire and its people.

KEY NPCs AND FACTIONS

VAELINDRA OF THE STILL WATERS — THE SEERESS

Role in the Campaign: The first major NPC the party meaningfully interacts with. She validates the shared vision, reframes it as potential rather than prophecy, and becomes a recurring resource, moral compass, and eventual source of one of the campaign's most significant revelations.

WHO SHE IS

Vaelindra is an elderly human woman—late seventies, perhaps older, difficult to tell—who has lived in the capital long enough to have watched three rulers come and go, including Empress Nyreeza. She was not always the Seeress. She arrived in the capital decades ago as a minor functionary in the Church of the Lupine Matron, bright and ambitious,

until her first genuine vision destroyed her career. What she saw conflicted with Church interests; the hierarchy quietly sidelined her, and she has operated independently ever since—not quite official, not quite heretical, merely tolerated. Powerful people consult her quietly and would never admit it publicly.

PRESENTATION AND MANNER

She is deliberately unmythical. No dramatic robes, no incense-filled chamber of mystery. She lives in a comfortable but modest apartment in a middle district of the capital, keeps meticulous written records of every vision she has ever interpreted, and receives visitors like a retired scholar receiving students. She is sharp, a little sardonic, and asks more questions than she answers. She has seen enough prophecy go wrong—interpreted incorrectly, weaponized politically, fulfilled in ways nobody anticipated—that she is deeply cautious about telling people what their visions “mean.”

HER GIFT

Her gift is genuine. She receives true visions from time to time, and she has an uncanny ability to recognize patterns across different people's prophetic experiences. When the party describes their shared vision, she will recognize elements she has encountered before—not the same vision, but related imagery, similar symbolic language. This unsettles her deeply, because it suggests something much larger than a personal omen: something already in motion.

WHAT SHE TELLS THE PARTY

She does not interpret the vision so much as confirm its legitimacy and share what she knows of its imagery. The shadow, the infernal fire, the burning capital—she has seen fragments of this before. She can tell the party the vision is real and connected to events already unfolding. But she pushes back firmly on the assumption that it is a prophecy of inevitable doom. In her experience, shared visions do not show what will happen—they show what could happen if nothing changes. This distinction preserves the party's agency: they are not spectators to a predetermined script but actors who may yet change the outcome.

RELATIONSHIP WITH THE THRONE

Her most complicated entanglement is with the imperial family. Empress Nyreeza consulted her regularly, and Vaelindra was one of the last people to see the Empress before her disappearance. She has never spoken of that final meeting to anyone. Emperor Qilvayas knows she exists and knows his mother trusted her, but he has never sought her out—possibly because he fears what she might tell him.

HER SECRET (DM ONLY)

Vaelindra's career-ending vision, decades ago, showed her fragments of the empire's true founding account—Zhuvedus, the broken oath, and the rival he destroyed to seize it (see *The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath*). That is precisely what the Church could not tolerate, and precisely why she was sidelined rather than elevated. She and Empress Nyreeza discussed this in their final meeting, and Vaelindra believes Nyreeza went looking for confirmation, or for the site itself, shortly before she vanished. Vaelindra also believes that Qilvayas's restoration project, however genuinely motivated, risks repeating his ancestor's exact error—that in his urgency to reunify the empire through law and order, he may yet break faith the way Zhuvedus once

did, and accelerate the very conditions that lead to the burning capital of the vision. She has not decided what to do with this knowledge, or whether the party can be trusted with it. This revelation should be deployed at a dramatically appropriate moment mid-campaign, once the party has earned her trust—or forced her hand.

RESOLVED DESIGN NOTES

How the party learns of her: resolved — Archivist Vell's referral (Session Two).

Church posture: resolved — active conflict. The Office of Omens surveils her (the ground-floor copyist reports to the Office; she knows, and feeds it chaff) and moves to a Writ of Examination in Session Six.

Her knowledge depth: resolved by tier — she knows the shape (the founding was a burial; the wound lies beneath; Nyreeza sought it) but withholds names and specifics until earned. Her forced-hand partial revelation is Session Six; the full account remains a mid-campaign payoff.

THE POWERS OF THE FRACTURED EMPIRE

Races, classes, and full stat blocks for the figures below appear in Appendices I–II. The rulers, commanders, and monsters who define the territories of the Atlas. Each profile notes its historical key — the real figure whose life supplies its spine — for the DM's reference in improvising beyond what is written.

DM Only — The Acceleration: One pattern connects these profiles, and no one on the board can see it. The shadow beneath Aenodira has been stirring since Empress Nyreeza reached the binding site three years ago — and its stirring leaks. Vaelindra's ledger records the visions quickening; Saint-Regent Olvesa's visions darkened the same season, which is why Orlath's coronation is suddenly imminent; the dreams that drive Ban Dregan's cruelty have worsened; the Skellvard's displacement, Norr's conquests, and the court's brittleness all sharpen in an empire growing subtly more faithless, more frightened, and more willing to break its word. The whole board is moving faster, and the players' campaign is the reason why. Never state this; let the tempo itself be the tell.

SEA-KING ALDREC THE LANDLESS — LORD OF THE SKELLVARD CLANS

Historical key: Alaric I. Aldrec, in his fifties now, served the empire in his youth — Skell oarsmen and shock-fighters were cheap, and at the Weeping Strait, twenty years ago, an imperial admiral spent three thousand of them to save his own squadrons and logged it as victory. Aldrec survived, was denied the coastal command he had been promised, and went home to find Ardven's expansion swallowing the fjords. He has led the ship-clans ever since as a king without a country, raiding the coast of the empire he would rather serve. His demands have never changed: a coastal march to hold, a title to hold it by, and his people's names entered in the empire's rolls as subjects rather than vermin. The throne has refused him four times — each refusal recorded, like everything, on the tally-sticks his lawspeakers keep. Speech pattern: fluent, formal Imperial — better than most courtiers' — which unsettles people who expected a savage; he counts silently in Skell when angry.

Threads: Aldrec is the campaign's great persuadable — the enemy who wants to be an ally, whom the empire keeps manufacturing into a threat. If Qilvayas grants him his march, the coast gains its fiercest defender and the restoration its strangest proof of concept. If refused too long, Aldrec will do something vast and terrible that solves nothing — and he knows it, which is the tragedy. DM Only: he is dying slowly of an old wound gone bad, and his succession is unsettled; the clans after Aldrec will not negotiate. The window he represents closes with him. Skell kings are buried under rivers, in secret; his greatest private fear is dying landless, with no river his people may safely turn.

MARSHAL GAVRIC DANE — THE YOUNG WOLF OF THE OSTMARK

Historical key: Germanicus. Gavric Dane is not yet thirty-five and already the most beloved soldier in the empire: the man who led the expedition that recovered the wolf-standard of the Ninth from the Brekelands, sixty years after the Silvasse Disaster swallowed three legions and every banner they carried. He weeps openly at soldiers' funerals, remembers the names of privates' children, refuses gifts he cannot reciprocate, and has never once, in any recorded word, expressed an ambition beyond his command — which is precisely why half the court is certain he must be hiding one. The legions call him the Young Wolf. The court hears that name and thinks of succession. The Emperor has met him twice, decorated him twice, and both times been perfectly, studiously correct — two disciplined young men, each aware the other is watching. Speech pattern: warm, direct, remembers everyone; goes quiet rather than lies.

Threads: Dane is a loyalty test the campaign can pose to every faction, including the party — everyone wants to claim him, use him, or remove him. DM Only: the Piso gun on the mantle — if Dane ever dies suddenly, the empire will tear itself apart over who is to blame, and at least three factions (the court, Orlath's agents, Norr) could plausibly want it. Whether that gun ever fires is the DM's call; its existence should shadow every scene he is in. He has begun having bad dreams he tells no one about. He has never broken an oath in his life. The shadow has no purchase on him — yet — and something in the dark finds that interesting.

BAN DREGAN MORN — WARDEN OF THE EASTMARCH, LORD OF THE FENCE

Historical key: Vlad III. Kinsman to Voivode Ysavet Morn, sent to the capital academy as a hostage-student forty years ago under the admission system's quiet diplomacy, returned to Tarnovar with perfect Imperial manners and something broken behind the eyes. For thirty years he has held the Eastmarch — Tarnovar's frontier with the Brekelands — and made it the safest road in the fractured west by a method the whole continent knows: the Fence, a mile of stakes along the border hills, and on the stakes, oath-breakers. Bandits who violated surrender terms. Mercenaries who turned on their employers. A Brekeland captain who burned a village under parley-sign. Tarnovari law makes oath-breaking the one unforgivable crime; Dregan enforces the law. Merchants bless his name. Peasants cross the border toward him. The Voivode has never sanctioned the Fence and never dismantled it, and that silence is the central fact of Tarnovari politics. Speech pattern: soft, courteous, academy-perfect Imperial; never raises his voice; asks questions he already knows the answers to.

Threads: Dregan is the campaign's question about order made flesh — Qilvayas restores through law, Norr through conquest, Dregan through terror in the name of the kept word, and the roads are safest in Dregan's march. DM Only: as a son of Threnvos's people, Dregan's obsessive punishment of oath-breakers is ancestral scar tissue he cannot name — and it has consequences he cannot see: the shadow, which feeds on broken oaths, finds the Eastmarch barren ground, and the nightmares that afflict oath-breakers cluster strangely at his border. He has noticed that the men he stakes die dreaming of a burning city. He has begun to wonder, in his cold patient way, what is listening. Of every soul on the board, Dregan is closest to guessing the campaign's secret from first principles.

DUCHESS EMERENN VASQ, NÉE MELDANE — THE DOWAGER OF THE SUTHMARK

Historical key: Catherine de' Medici. Born to Velmareth's great Meldane banking house, married young into the Suthmark's ducal line to seal a grain-and-credit compact, widowed at forty, and ruler in all but name ever since through her sons — the sickly young Duke Aldous and his ambitious younger brother, Tavian. The devout south never fully accepted the merchant's daughter, and she never asked it to; she governs through the Garland, her web of ladies-in-waiting, governesses, wine-factors, and priests' housekeepers, which knows what the Suthmark is thinking before the Suthmark does. Her defining wound is the Vintage Night, six years past: Orlathine congregations massacred in three towns during the harvest festival. She gave an order that night — what she meant by it and what it became are not the same thing — and rather than be seen to have lost control, she let the realm believe she meant all of it. The Suthmark fears her now. She has decided fear will serve. Speech pattern: exquisitely courteous; deploys her dead husband's opinions as cover for her own; switches to Velmarene idiom when she wants you to know the courtesy has ended.

Threads: Vasq holds the capital's food supply, which makes her patience the empire's most strategic resource. She bridges three regions — Meldane money in Velmareth, Suthmark grain, and the Orlath schism bleeding into her provinces — and she has quietly opened her own channels to Orlath, not from sympathy but because she hedges everything. DM Only: the truth of the Vintage Night order — now canon: a limited arrest that cascaded into massacre, which she chose to own rather than be seen to have lost control — is her breakable point — proof of what she actually said exists in a Garland lady's cipher-diary, and its surfacing would either humanize or destroy her. She knows about Countess Ory's hill country and its vanishing girls; she has done nothing, because the Ory estates hold Vasq debts, and she is waiting for the accusation to become profitable. The gothic horror in her south is, to her, an account not yet due.

COUNTESS VELSANNA ORY OF GREYWELL

Historical key: Elizabeth Báthory. The Ory family has held the grey hill country of the eastern Suthmark for four hundred years, and Castle Greywell has always been the kind of place the valley folk are relieved not to be invited to. Countess Velsanna is the last of the main line: a widow of vast estates and vaster loans — the crown itself owes the Ory treasury sums it has no intention of repaying — famously charitable at a distance, famously beautiful in a way that does not change. Her age is a local superstition: church records make her seventy; travelers who glimpse her at her

gates describe a woman of forty. Servant girls take the good wages at Greywell and, some seasons, do not come home. The families are paid grief-silver. The local priest writes letters that are never answered. Nobody with power has ever had a reason to look, and everyone without power has excellent reasons not to. Speech pattern: gracious, old-fashioned, faintly amused, with the unhurried attention of something that has never once needed to rush.

Threads: Greywell is the campaign's pure gothic horror — deliberately unconnected to the shadow, because a living world grows its own evils, and the party should not be able to assume every darkness is the metaplot. DM Only: the horror is real. Velsanna sustains her youth by old blood-rite sorcery [mechanism to be detailed if she enters play — a hag-bargain, a fiendish compact, and an inherited rite are all viable; choose when needed], and the count of the missing runs past forty girls across two decades. The bitter irony preserved from history: when power finally moves against her, it will move for the debts, not the dead — and the party may be the only force in the world that ever comes for the girls' sake. As a villain she is beatable at almost any tier; as an institution — the silence, the grief-silver, the unanswered letters — she is a preview of every fight the campaign will ever pose.

SAINT-REGENT OLVEA THE RECONCILED — FOUNDER OF THE SEE OF ORLATH

Historical key: Olga of Kiev. Sixty years ago she was the young widow-regent of a northern principality whose lord had been murdered under guest-right by the Drevic clan-lords — and what she did about it is still told in the north in four movements, each worse than the last: the envoys buried alive with their gifts; the lodge burned with the second delegation feasting inside it; the funeral-feast on her husband's barrow where three hundred Drevic notables drank themselves helpless among her soldiers; and the birds — the tribute of sparrows and doves from every Drevic roof, released home at dusk with fire tied to their feet. Then, with her vengeance complete and her name a horror, she walked into a mountain shrine of the Matron and did not come out for a year. What came out was the woman the north now calls the Reconciled: founder of the See of Orlath, architect of its plain and rigorous rite, and the nearest thing the fractured world has to a living saint — a title she accepts with visible distaste, because she alone keeps the full ledger of what it cost. She rejects the capital Church not from doctrine first but from knowledge: she has seen, from the inside, exactly what absolution in the service of power looks like. Speech pattern: plain, spare, scripture-cadenced; never euphemizes her own past — refers to the four vengeance as "my instruction," meaning what taught her.

Threads: Olvesa is the campaign's test of whether redemption is real — a genuinely holy woman with a river of blood behind her, leading a genuinely purer church toward a genuinely catastrophic act. DM Only: her visions are true. Fragments of the storm and the wrong fire have reached her for decades, and three years ago — the season Nyreeza vanished — they darkened sharply. She reads them as the Matron's verdict on the corrupt capital and its oath-broken throne, and it is this conviction, not ambition, that has moved the coronation of her grandson from someday to now. She is, in perfect sincerity, about to crown a rival emperor because the shadow's stirring told her to. If anyone could ever show her what the visions actually are, the entire northern crisis would turn on that conversation.

KING KARVEL OF ARDVEN — THE UNCROWNED EMPEROR OF THE NORTH

Historical key: Charlemagne. Grandson of Saint-Regent Olvesa, king of a realm he assembled himself: fifteen years of war, marriage, and administration that turned a dozen northern crowns and clan-lands into Ardven. Karvel is broad, loud, semi-lettered and obsessed with letters — he reads slowly and has founded forty monastery schools; he sleeps four hours and audits his reeves personally; he prays like a soldier and legislates like a clerk. He is, in every way the capital would find uncomfortable to admit, what Qilvayas is trying to become: a unifier whose restoration is actually working. And within the year, if nothing intervenes, his grandmother's church will crown him Emperor of the True Rite — a second empire, sanctified by a second church, in direct and explicit denial of the Lupine Throne's mandate. Karvel himself is ambivalent in private: he wants the crown's legitimacy for his heirs, distrusts the theology, and suspects — correctly — that the coronation makes eventual war with the south very hard to avoid. Speech pattern: booming, blunt, unexpectedly precise on numbers; quotes scripture slightly wrong and dares anyone to correct him.

Threads: the coronation is the campaign's second structural clock, set for the same year as the Zhuvedian Laws' promulgation — two rival covenants, sworn at opposite ends of the world, in the same season [DM note: the collision of these clocks is deliberate; whatever else the mid-campaign holds, that year should feel like a hinge of history]. Karvel is not a villain: he is a good king building a rival answer to the same question Qilvayas is asking, and the party may find his answer persuasive. DM Only: a coronation is an oath sworn before a god — and the entity beneath Aenodira, born from a broken covenant at an empire's founding, will be listening with two thousand years of attention when a new empire swears its founding covenant. What that means in practice is deliberately open: design the consequence when the campaign approaches it.

DUKE GARVIN NORR — THE BASTARD OF NORMERE

Historical key: William the Conqueror. Baseborn son of the old Duke of Normere, acknowledged but never legitimized, who survived three assassination attempts before the age of twenty, killed the last of his trueborn rivals in the field at twenty-four, and has spent the two decades since building the most ruthlessly administered state west of Aenodira. Norr's conquest of the Brekelands proceeds warlord by warlord, and it is not pillage — it is absorption: every conquered holding is surveyed into the Reckoning Book, every landholder swears the personal oath to Norr himself over the heads of all intermediate lords, and every sworn man's obligations, taxes, and levies are recorded, audited, and enforced. Where submission is offered, terms are kept to the letter. Where it is refused — the Harrowing of the Weld, four years ago, ended a district's rebellion by ending, for a generation, the district. He claims descent from an old imperial governor's line and styles his conquest "the restoration of lawful administration," which has the special insolence of being partly true. Speech pattern: flat, economical, deliberately unceremonious; recites exact figures from memory as intimidation; the word "bastard" goes unremarked in his presence exactly once.

Threads: Norr is Qilvayas's dark mirror — restoration by conquest and ledger against restoration by law and consent — and the empire's most dangerous rival precisely because

his subjects' lives measurably improve. His westward absorption of the Brekelands is on a collision course with Ban Dregan's Eastmarch, and what happens when the Reckoning Book meets the Fence is one of the campaign's promised storms. DM Only: the personal oaths are the detail that matters. Norr has bound tens of thousands of souls to himself by sworn word — the largest concentration of living oaths in the fractured world — and he keeps his side of every one of them, scrupulously, as policy. He has, without knowing it, built either the shadow's greatest feast (if he ever breaks faith at scale) or the strongest oath-bound bulwark on the continent (if he never does). A single great betrayal by Norr would feed the entity beyond anything since the fracture began. He must never learn that. Certain other parties, late in the campaign, might try to arrange it.

GEOGRAPHY AND LOCATIONS

AENODIRA: THE IMPERIAL CAPITAL

Aenodira sits where the Ostrun bends into a wide horseshoe against its northern approach, and the city has grown, ring by ring, to fill everything the river's curve allows and then some. Three walls circle it, each raised in a different age of the empire and each still wearing the color of the age that built it: the Founder's Wall, innermost and oldest, dark and roughly hewn; the High Wall, pale gold limestone raised at the height of imperial wealth, wide-gated and half ceremonial; and the Long Wall, outermost, red brick thrown up fast during the empire's last great expansion — the one that came right before the fracture began. Walking outward from the palace is walking backward through two hundred years of the empire's confidence, ring by ring, until the confidence runs out.

Aenodira is inland, definitively: well up the Ostrun's valley, with river trade through Rivergate but no ocean harbor of any kind — the nearest salt water is Velmareth's delta, ten days downriver. Every approach is therefore a road or the river, and which one shapes a traveler before they ever see the walls: four days from the Ostmark through loyalist country that still mostly functions; two weeks from the Brekelands, where banditry is the ambient condition rather than the exception; three weeks down from Tarnovar's highlands, where the Fence's deterrence ends at Fencagate and does not follow you into the Crownlands; or up the Ostrun itself from Velmareth — river traffic with a different flavor of risk entirely, tolls and smugglers and whatever operates out of Rivergate's quieter berths, rather than anything so honest as highway robbery.

The Long Wall was built on the assumption that the city would keep growing to fill it. It didn't. The result is an outer city that is unevenly occupied — half-finished districts standing empty beside others crammed well past any sensible density — and that unevenness, more than any single landmark, is what the outer ring is actually about.

THE INNER CITY

Contained within the Founder's Wall, the oldest heart of Aenodira is where the empire's two great authorities face each other across a shallow valley: the palace on one rise, the Temple on the other, close enough that a bell rung in one is heard clearly in the other — which everyone who has ever

needed to negotiate between throne and altar has found either convenient or ominous, depending on which side of the negotiation they were on.

HIGHCOURT

The palace district, called Highcourt by everyone except the clerks who insist on “the Palatine Precinct” in official correspondence, holds the Lupine Throne, the ministries that keep what remains of the empire’s paperwork running, and the townhouses of whatever nobility still bothers to maintain a capital residence. It is guarded, aloof, and quieter than a city this size has any right to be at its literal center — quiet in the particular way of a place where everyone is watching everyone else’s movements and nobody wants to be the one who made noise.

The Long Course, a broad ceremonial avenue and parade ground running along Highcourt’s eastern edge, is where the legions march on imperial holidays, where new laws are read aloud to whatever public gathers to hear them, and where the proclamations of the coming Zhuvedian Laws are currently posted at every crossing. It is also, not incidentally, the traditional site of public executions, though the current reign has used it for that purpose only twice.

Power and Presence: Access to the Emperor himself runs through Lord Chamberlain Vareth Kessin, a career bureaucrat who has outlasted two regents and one attempted reform of his own office, and who treats every petitioner’s business as simultaneously vital and faintly beneath him. Nothing reaches Qilvayas without passing Kessin’s desk first, which makes Kessin one of the most quietly powerful people in the empire and one of the least visible.

THE SANCTUM

Across the valley from Highcourt, the Sanctum climbs the second of the city’s two hills toward the golden dome of the Great Temple of the Matron — visible, on a clear day, from every ring of the city and from the pilgrim road for a day’s travel before arrival. Beneath and around the Temple proper spreads the Church’s actual machinery: administrative halls, seminaries, the residences of a clergy that ranges from genuinely devout to comfortably political, and the Office of Omens, whose officials would very much like to be the empire’s sole authority on visions, portents, and divine will, and who resent, with real institutional bitterness, that they are not.

Power and Presence: Matriarch Ilsevet Corvane, Voice of the Matron in the capital, is the Church’s most senior public figure in Aenodira — not its supreme authority (that distinction is more contested, and more interesting, than any single title suggests), but its face, its administrator, and the person any official inquiry into the party’s shared vision would eventually land on. She is neither villain nor ally by default; she is institution, and institutions protect themselves first and ask questions about truth second. The Office of Omens answers to her, nominally.

THE OLD FORUM

Tucked against the inside of the Founder’s Wall, in the oldest and least renovated corner of the Inner City, the Old Forum is what remains of Aenodira before it was a capital — a warren of foundation-stones, half-buried columns, and one weathered monument to Zhuvedus himself, worn smooth by two thousand years of hands touching it for luck on the way

to somewhere else. Scholars catalogue it. Beggars and the genuinely destitute shelter in it. Nobody has excavated it properly in living memory, because proper excavation would mean admitting how little the Church and the imperial cult actually agree on what they’d find there.

DM Only: Confirmed canon: the binding site lies beneath the Old Forum’s foundations, reached through the catacombs that everyone knows exist and nobody has fully mapped, descending into the Undercourt’s deepest reach. All future site design builds on this as fixed ground.

THE UNDERCOURT (DM ONLY)

Aenodira stands on Aenodira. Beneath the modern city lies a connected pre-imperial stratum — the Undercourt — the buried remains of whatever stood here before Zhuvedus’s founding: black roughly-hewn stone of the same make as the Founder’s Wall, streets three man-heights below the current ones, and chambers that predate every map the empire keeps. The catacombs under the Old Forum touch it. So, in places, do the deep vaults under Scholar’s Row — including the academy’s decommissioned Undervault, which matters in Sessions Three and Four. The Church has never excavated it; the imperial cult has never asked to; both institutions’ disinterest is older than anyone can account for and functions, in practice, like a door everyone has agreed not to try.

In the Undercourt’s deepest reach lies the binding site — the place the oath was broken and Threnvos died. The descent as far as the Second Seal is now built and canon (see Session Six); what lies beyond the Seal remains the next major build. Established features: cold that deepens with proximity (the same cold as Dren’s medallion); pre-imperial inscriptions in a script the Church does not teach; and evidence, in at least two places, of a careful modern visitor — hairline survey marks in Empress Nyreeza’s personal cipher, three years old. She found a way down. Whether she found a way back up is the campaign’s open wound.

THE MIDDLE CITY

Beyond the High Wall, Aenodira does its actual work. This is where most of the city’s population lives, trades, studies, and prays without any particular proximity to power — and where the party will spend most of their time in the capital.

COPPERGATE

Already familiar to the party by the time they reach it: copyists, instrument-makers, retired functionaries, laundry strung between balconies, and, above a copyist’s shop on Ninth Lane, the blue-shuttered apartment of Vaelindra of the Still Waters. Coppergate is comfortable, unglamorous, and exactly the kind of place someone chooses when they want to be findable only by people who already know where to look.

SCHOLAR’S ROW

Home to the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne — swept courts, ringing bells, restricted archives kept by Archivist Dathenor Vell — along with the smaller tutoring houses, instrument shops, and cheap lodging-houses that cluster around any institution full of young people with stipends. The party’s dormitory years live here. So, less pleasantly, does the reputation the academy has spent decades trying to shed: everyone in Scholar’s Row has an opinion about which students are lottery winners and which

are hostages, and most of those opinions are wrong in interesting ways.

THE EXCHANGE

Aenodira's guildhalls, counting-houses, and covered markets, where what remains of the empire's trade actually changes hands. Merchant Republic delegations keep permanent offices here — officially trade missions, unofficially outposts of exactly the disorder-preferring interests already described under the empire's current political landscape.

Power and Presence: Guildmaster Ptolan Vess, head of the Capital Merchants' Concord, is the closest thing the Exchange has to a single voice, though "closest thing" undersells how little the guilds actually agree with each other. Vess is pragmatic, genuinely apolitical by temperament, and privately convinced that Qilvayas's restoration project is bad for business regardless of whether it succeeds.

THE GARRISON

Barracks, drill yards, and the administrative offices of whatever legion elements are currently garrisoned in the capital — a smaller and more ceremonial presence than the empire once kept here, which everyone in the Garrison is uncomfortably aware of.

Power and Presence: Legate Bruvasca Thorne commands the Palatine Guard, the capital's actual defensive force, and maintains a professional, faintly weary correspondence with provincial magistrates — including, as it happens, Cassivar Ondrei of Dravenna, whose complaint against the Third Legion's colonel is currently sitting somewhere in Thorne's inbox, exactly as slow-moving as every other piece of institutional accountability in the empire.

THE OUTER CITY

THE ARCHWORK

An old imperial aqueduct crosses the outer city on a run of high stone arches, most of it still functional, several sections long since bricked up and converted into multi-story housing wedged directly into the arch spans. Rent is cheap because the housing is, structurally speaking, a repurposed water pipe, and everyone who lives there knows it. Nickname aside, the Archwork is a working-class district in the ordinary sense — laborers, small tradespeople, the families of Garrison rank-and-file who can't afford anything closer to the center.

FARROWGATE

The newest and least planned district in the city, growing without much municipal help along the Long Wall's inner face, populated overwhelmingly by displaced people from the fractured territories — not any single group, but a slow accretion of every border skirmish, warlord dispute, and burned village that has sent someone walking toward the capital because an old story said the throne feeds its own. Established Aenodirans call it Farrowgate without much affection; the people who live there increasingly use the name themselves, the way a slur gets worn down into an identity by people who didn't get to choose it.

This is not where Semya's people from Halvenne ended up, if the party helped resettle them in Dravenna — but it is exactly where they would have ended up if the party hadn't.

RIVERGATE

The docks and river trade quarter, where goods — and a fair amount that isn't quite goods — move in and out of the capital. Less prestigious than the Exchange, less regulated, and considerably more interesting to anyone investigating something the empire's official record doesn't want to explain, including, plausibly, wherever Odric Hale bought his dead Roads Commission seal.

None of this is exhaustive, and it isn't meant to be — Aenodira should grow the way real capitals do, one specific street or shopfront named the moment a scene actually needs it, built outward from this framework rather than pre-mapped down to the alley. What's fixed for now: the three rings and their walls, the two hills of Highcourt and the Sanctum, Coppergate's location relative to the Academy, and the Old Forum as the confirmed location above the binding site (DM only).

Whatever lies beneath the capital—the likely site of the broken oath and Threnvos's death (see The Founding Myth: Zhuvedus and the Broken Oath)—should be developed alongside the capital itself, since the two are now the same design problem.

PLOT HOOKS AND ADVENTURE SEEDS

Seeds already planted by Sessions Zero through Four, ready to grow when the table needs them. Each is deliberately small enough to run as a side thread and connected enough to pay into the main arc.

The Colonel's Reckoning: Ondrei's complaint against Colonel Aurel Dessen of the Third Legion grinds through Legate Thorne's office. The colonel has friends, the surviving deserters' testimony needs protecting, and the party is the reason there is a case at all. A courtroom-and-intimidation arc in the Ostmark — and a test of whether the system Qilvayas is rebuilding can actually convict one of its own.

The Seal Dealer of Rivergate (engaged: Session Five): Odric Hale's dead Roads Commission seal came from somewhere. The dealer trades in the seals, signets, and letterheads of abolished imperial offices — and someone has recently bought the seals of offices that handled the old censuses of the Founder's Wall district. Who wants to forge authority over the oldest records in the city, and why now?

Forty Witnesses: Semya's people, resettled in Dravenna (or struggling in Farrowgate if not), become a listening post and a responsibility. When trouble reaches them — a landlord, a press-gang, a recruiter for someone's private army — the party learns what their earlier kindness actually bought, and what it obligates.

The Office of Omens Moves (engaged: Sessions Five–Six): Prelate Odell's office hears of a full academy cohort, a shared dream, and an unsanctioned consultation in Coppergate — and under its new posture, it does not merely open a file. Surveillance, a summons with teeth, and ultimately a Writ of Examination against Vaelindra herself. The courtesy remains; the patience does not. How the party handles being hunted by paperwork shapes their standing with the Church for the entire campaign.

The Cold Door (engaged: Session Six): The unscripted door in the Undervault (Sessions Three and Four) does not

go away. Masons re-seal the wing; the party holds a rubbing of cipher marks Vell can identify as the Empress's hand. The first thread of the Nyreeza trail, and the campaign's standing invitation to go beneath the city.

A Clerk from Highcourt (engaged: Session Five): Someone from Chamberlain Kessin's office observed the Proving. The newly chartered company receives its first real commission – modest, deniable, and a test with the throne's fingerprints kept carefully off it. Passing it opens the palace door an inch.

The Tarnovar Envoy: A rare Tarnovari delegation comes to Aenodira – trade terms, nominally – and its members unsettle everyone: they will not swear on the Matron, they touch stone before signing anything, and one of their singers performs a ballad of Vosthren the Betrayed within earshot of the wrong scholar. A slow fuse to the campaign's largest buried revelation.

The Medallion Grows Colder: Dren's defaced oath-medallion is a barometer nobody knows how to read yet. Days when it is colder correlate – the party will eventually notice – with news of some notable broken faith somewhere in the fracturing empire. A quiet, persistent instrument for seeding the central mechanism without a word of exposition.

The Landless King's Fifth Petition: Sea-King Aldrec sends envoys to Aenodira one more time – tally-sticks, formal Imperial, and an offer to hold the coast against his own displaced kin in exchange for a march and a title. The court means to refuse him again. Anyone – the party included – who grasps what is actually being offered has a narrow window to change the answer before the window closes with Aldrec's failing health.

The Grey-Gold Rising: When the Zhuvedian Laws' tax provisions are posted along the Long Course, the capital's race-day factions – Golds and Greys, enemies by tradition – discover common cause for the first time in living memory. A capital riot in the Justinianic mold [proposed future event]: the day Qilvayas must choose between mercy and massacre, with the party positioned wherever their choices have put them.

The Coronation Clock: Orlath prepares to crown King Karvel Emperor of the True Rite within the year – the same year as the Laws' promulgation. Two rival covenants, one season. Embassies, sabotage, desperate diplomacy, and the question nobody in the capital is asking: why now? (The DM knows: Olvesa's visions darkened three years ago. See The Powers of the Fractured Empire.)

The Girls of Greywell: A Farrowgate family begs the newly chartered company to find a daughter who took service in the Suthmark hills and stopped writing. The trail leads to Castle Greywell, grief-silver, unanswered letters – and a horror with four hundred years of rank and no connection at all to the shadow. Some evils are just evils. The party may be the first force that ever comes for the girls' sake.

The Book and the Fence: Norr's surveyors reach the eastern Brekeland hills within sight of Ban Dregan's stakes. Two absolute systems of order regard each other across a valley. Whoever is standing between them – refugees, merchants, a party on a job – gets to watch history decide whether the Reckoning Book and the Fence can share a border.

THE IMPERIAL CALENDAR

Twelve months, opening at the year's turn in deep winter with the Matron's own liturgical season, running the plain

agricultural cycle everyone actually lives by, and closing with her second high month before the year turns again.

Month	Season	Character
Wolfmoon	Deep winter (year begins)	The Matron's high liturgical month; the year turns in her keeping, not the sun's.
Thawtide	Late winter	Roads reopen; the Ostmark's watch-forts change garrison.
Sowmonth	Early spring	Suthmark planting begins; the year's first oaths of service are traditionally sworn.
Greening	Mid-spring	Long Course racing season opens (Golds vs. Greys).
Solacre	Early summer	Court business in full swing; the Zhuvedian Laws are slated for a Solacre reading.
Haymonth	Midsummer	Rural labor peak; Academy field exercises traditionally run Hay-Harvestide.
Harvestide	Early autumn	The Suthmark's great harvest festival – and the Vintage Night fell in Harvestide.
Vinmoon	Mid-autumn	Grape harvest; Suthmark vintages are dated by Vinmoon year.
Fallowmonth	Late autumn	Fields rest; Suthmark inheritance customarily settles at Fallowmonth's turn.
Greywane	Early winter	Days shorten; the Long Course racing season closes.
Longdark	Deep winter	The Matron's second high month, mirroring Wolfmoon; Vigil Halls keep continuous watch.
Threshold	Year's end	A short, liminal

		month of 20 days — old debts settled, old oaths renewed, before Wolfmoon turns the year.
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Loyalist territory counts Years of the Reckoning (YR) from the Founding, the exact figure left deliberately soft. Orlath keeps YR for trade and secular record-keeping but privately dates its liturgical documents from the Reconciliation, Olvesa’s year in the shrine — even the schismatics haven’t stopped using the empire’s clock, they’ve simply started keeping a second one. Tarnovar mostly dispenses with numbered years for internal purposes, marking time by successive Voivodes’ reigns instead. A light seven-day week — a market day, a rest day tied to Vigil-keeping, five working days — completes the structure without inventing texture nobody will use at the table.

CAMPAIGN TIMELINE AND PACING

Chronology of established events, relative to the campaign’s present day (the party’s final field exercise, five weeks before commencement). Dates are framed as “years ago” to stay portable if a calendar is adopted later.

~2,000 years ago: The founding. Zhuvedus breaks the sworn covenant, destroys Threnvos, and establishes the empire alone. The binding site seals whatever remained. Threnvos’s surviving people scatter west; their descendants become Tarnovar.

~200 years ago: The fracture begins. Provinces fall away over the following two centuries; every abandoned fealty and torn treaty feeds what waits beneath the capital.

~60 years ago: The Silvasse Disaster: three legions and their wolf-standards lost in the western woods — the fracture’s military nadir, and the wound Marshal Dane’s recovery of the Ninth’s standard has begun, sixty years on, to heal.

~60–45 years ago: In the north: the murder of Olvesa’s lord under guest-right, her four vengeance against the Drevec clans, her year in the mountain shrine, and the founding of the See of Orlath (~45 years ago).

~50 years ago: Vaelindra’s career-ending vision — fragments of the true founding — and her quiet removal from the Church. She begins her independent ledger of visions.

~40 years ago: A young Dregan Morn arrives at the capital academy as a hostage-student of Tarnovar; he returns home a decade later, changed.

~20 years ago: The Weeping Strait: an imperial admiral spends three thousand Skell auxiliaries to save his squadrons. Aldrec survives, is denied his promised command, and begins his kingship of the displaced. In the west, Garvin Norr kills the last of his trueborn rivals and takes Normere in fact.

~15 years ago: Karvel begins the consolidation of the northern crowns into Ardven; the ship-clans lose their fjords over the following years and turn south.

~12 years ago: Empress Nyreeza begins the academy revival and the first institutional reforms — and, somewhere in these years, her private inquiry into the founding.

11 years ago: Archivist Vell’s last referral to Vaelindra — the one that ended badly. He has not presumed on her since.

6 years ago: The Vintage Night: Orlathine congregations massacred in three Suthmark towns during the harvest festival. Duchess Vasq owns an order she may not have meant. The south learns to fear her.

4 years ago: The Harrowing of the Weld: Duke Norr ends a district’s rebellion, and the district, for a generation. The west learns what his patience costs.

3 years ago: Nyreeza’s final meeting with Vaelindra; her disappearance shortly after. Vaelindra’s ledger records the vision-fragments accelerating from this season — and, unknown to the capital, Saint-Regent Olvesa’s visions darken the same season, setting the coronation in motion. A six-month search and interregnum follows.

~2.5 years ago: Qilvayas’s coronation. The restoration project begins in earnest: the Law Commission under Archjurist Vhal, the academy expansion, the diplomatic overtures.

Within the coming year: Two clocks, one season: the planned promulgation of the Zhuvedian Laws in Aenodira, and the coronation of Karvel as Emperor of the True Rite in Orlath. Rival covenants at opposite ends of the world — the restoration’s point of no return, and its first true rival. Every faction in the empire is already positioning.

Present day: The party’s field exercise, the vision, the return to Aenodira, and the Proving. Commencement — moved up for the Proven cohort — follows Session Four.

Pacing guidance: the Zhuvedian Laws promulgation is the campaign’s first structural clock — events the party does not attend to will still move toward it. The three-year freshness of Nyreeza’s disappearance means her trail is warm: witnesses remember, her cipher marks are recent, and her son’s grief is a live political fact rather than settled history. Vaelindra’s correlation — the visions accelerating from the season the Empress vanished — is the connective tissue the party can discover early, and it is true: whatever Nyreeza did at the binding site changed something.

APPENDIX I — THE ROSTER: RACES AND CLASSES

Class entries are archetype keys for flavor and improvisation — NPC stat blocks remain custom-built per DMG practice, not class-leveled builds. ‘Statted’ marks the ten who receive full blocks in Part IV.

Name	Race	Class / Archetype	Power Tier	Statted
Emper or Qilvayas	Drow	Paladin (Crown-sworn)	CR 9	Yes
Legate Bruvasca Thorne	Human	Fighter (Battle Master)	CR 10	Yes
Marsha l Gavric Dane	Human	Fighter (Champion, leader)	CR 7	Yes
Ban Dregan	Human	Paladin (Oath of	CR 9	Yes

Morn		Vengeanc e)		
Sea- King Aldrec	Human	Fighter (raider- king)	CR 7	Yes
Duke Garvin Norr	Human	Fighter (mastermi nd- general)	CR 8	Yes
King Karvel	Human	Fighter (Champion, crowned)	CR 8	Yes
Saint- Regent Olvesa	Human	Cleric (Life, true visions)	CR 10	Yes
Mistres s Averil Shen	Human	Rogue (Masterm ind)	CR 6	Yes
Prelate Sarvin Odell	Human	Cleric (Knowled ge)	CR 5	Yes
Empres s Nyreeza (absent)	Drow	Wizard (scholar- sovereign)	— (fate open)	No — by design
Vaelind ra of the Still Waters	Human	Seer (no class; true visions)	Nonco mbatant	No — by design
Duches s Emerenn Vasq	Human	Noble (Masterm ind; the Garland)	Social CR 4	Social block later
Counte ss Velsanna Ory	Human	Blood- rite sorceress	Deferr ed	Greyw ell module
Voivod e Ysavet Morn	Human	Noble (elder stateswo man)	Social	No
Lord Chamberl ain Kessin	Human	Noble (gatekeep er)	Social	No
Archjur ist Senna Vhal	Half-elf	Expert (jurist)	Social	No
Hierop hant Malzeth Corr	Human	Cleric (imperial cult)	CR 3- equiv	No
Matriar ch Ilsevet Corvane	Human	Cleric (institutio nal)	CR 7- equiv	No
Archivi st Dathenor Vell	Hill dwarf	Sage (archivist)	Nonco mbatant	No

Magist er Corvin Dail	Human	Fighter (drillmast er)	CR 5- equiv	No
Chance llor Emeth Sorrall	Half-elf (canon)	Noble (mage- lite)	Social	No
Instruc tor Liria Fenn	Human	Bard (College of Lore)	CR 4- equiv	No
Magistr ate Cassivar Ondrei	Human	Noble/ Expert (magistrat e)	Social	No
Sgt. Petra Malich	Human	Fighter (soldier)	CR 1 (statted, S2)	Existin g
Odric Hale	Human	Rogue (charlatan)	CR 1/2 (statted, S2)	Existin g
Clerk Ossian Pell	Human	Comm oner (clerk)	—	No
Tirell Mosse	Rock gnome	Expert (dealer)	—	No
Brune Halloc	Half- orc	Fighter (dock boss)	CR 2 (statted, S5)	Existin g
The Widow Brakka	Hill dwarf	Comm oner (landlady, undefeat ed)	Beyond CR	No
Censor -Captain Ferrin Odo	Human	Fighter (church soldier)	CR 3 (statted, S6)	Existin g
Ilinca Verath	Human (Tarnovar i)	Bard (ballad- keeper)	—	No
Warlor ds Skarn & Voss	Human	Fighter s (veterans)	CR 3- 4-equiv	No
Colonel Aurel Dessen	Human	Fighter (corrupt officer)	CR 3- equiv	No
Marsha l Dane's analog gap — Yanna, Semya, Vorn, Tobble, Bram, Tavian, Aldous	Human	Comm oners / Nobles	—	No

APPENDIX II — STAT

BLOCKS OF THE POWERS

Custom NPC blocks keyed to class archetypes, validated against the DMG Monster Statistics by Challenge Rating table and SRD analogs (validation summary at section end). Design intent: these are human legends, not demigods — the CR 6–10 band means a mid-campaign party could theoretically fight any of them, which is exactly the right scale; their true power is armies, institutions, and oaths, not hit points.

Emperor Qilvayas

Medium humanoid (Drow), lawful neutral — Paladin (Crown-sworn)

Armor Class: 18 (ceremonial plate under robes of state)

Hit Points: 123 (19d8 + 38)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws: Wis +6, Cha +8

Skills: History +7, Insight +6, Persuasion +8, Religion +7

Senses: darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Elvish, three provincial tongues

Challenge: 9 (5,000 XP)

The Crown Oath. Qilvayas is sworn to the empire itself, and the Matron answers: his paladin gifts function. (DM only: that his oath holds — that the goddess still answers the dynasty of the Oathbreaker — is itself a theological fact of enormous, unexamined weight.)

Aura of the Throne. Allies within 10 feet of Qilvayas can't be frightened and add +2 to saving throws while he is conscious.

The Founder's Mercy. Qilvayas carries a healing pool of 45 hit points (as Lay on Hands). He spends it on others. Always on others.

Spellcasting. Half-caster (spell save DC 16): command, zone of truth, dispel magic, and — once per day — a divination that he has never cast, because he is afraid of the answer.

Fey Ancestry / Sunlight Sensitivity (adapted). Advantage vs. charm; immune to magical sleep. The Founder's Blood has long since adapted to the sun — no sensitivity — but the dynasty's great liturgies are sung at night, and he is, visibly, most himself after dark.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Qilvayas makes two attacks with Vigil, the dynastic longsword.

Vigil (Longsword). Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage plus 9 (2d8) radiant damage — the Founder's light, which the court has not seen him draw in anger, ever.

REACTIONS

Sovereign's Interposition. When a creature within 5 feet of Qilvayas is hit by an attack, he can make himself the target instead. His guards hate this. He does it anyway.

Legate Bruvasca Thorne

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral — Fighter (Battle Master)

Armor Class: 18 (plate)

Hit Points: 143 (22d8 + 44)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Str +9, Con +6

Skills: Athletics +9, History +7, Insight +6, Perception +6

Senses: passive Perception 16

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Skell

Challenge: 10 (5,900 XP)

Ashline Discipline. Allied creatures within 30 feet of Thorne can't be surprised, and gain +10 feet of speed when moving toward a position she designates (free, once per round).

Indomitable (2/Day). Thorne can reroll a failed saving throw.

Superiority (5d10/rest). Maneuver dice fueling her Riposte, Trip, and Rally (grant an ally 15 temporary hit points) — spend as the fiction demands.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Thorne makes three longsword attacks.

Longsword (two-handed). Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage. On a Trip maneuver, add 1d10 and the target saves (Str DC 17) or falls prone.

REACTIONS

Riposte. When a creature misses Thorne with a melee attack, she spends a superiority die and attacks it: +9 to hit, 12 (2d6 + 5) + 5 (1d10) slashing.

Marshal Gavric Dane, the Young Wolf

Medium humanoid (human), lawful good — Fighter (Champion, leader)

Armor Class: 18 (plate)

Hit Points: 110 (17d8 + 34)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws: Str +7, Con +5

Skills: Animal Handling +5, Athletics +7, Persuasion +7

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial

Challenge: 7 (2,900 XP)

The Standard Holds. Allies within 30 feet who can see Dane have advantage on saving throws against being frightened and add +1 to attack rolls. If Dane falls, every ally who saw it makes a DC 15 Wisdom save or is frightened 1 round — and then gains his +1 permanently for the battle. (The legions would burn the world for him. That is the problem.)

For the Ninth! (Recharge 5–6). Dane makes three additional longsword attacks, split among targets, and allies within 30 feet may each use their reaction to move 10 feet.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Dane makes three longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage (versatile, two-handed). Critical on 19–20.

Ban Dregan Morn, Lord of the Fence

Medium humanoid (human, Tarnovari), lawful neutral (evil methods) — Paladin (Oath of Vengeance)

Armor Class: 17 (splint, meticulous)

Hit Points: 130 (20d8 + 40)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)

Saving Throws: Wis +7, Cha +7

Skills: Insight +7, Intimidation +7, Religion +6

Senses: passive Perception 13

Languages: Common, Old Imperial (academy-perfect), Tarnovari, Dwarvish

Challenge: 9 (5,000 XP)

Sanction of the Broken Word. Dregan's weapon attacks deal an extra 9 (2d8) radiant damage against any creature that has knowingly broken a sworn oath. (DM adjudication — and the grim joke is that against bandits, deserters, and most of the fractured world's soldiery, everyone qualifies. His power works almost everywhere he points it. He has noticed. It is part of what he is becoming.)

Vow of Enmity (1/Day). Bonus action: advantage on attack rolls against one creature for 1 minute.

Aura of the Stakes. Enemies within 10 feet of Dregan who have broken a sworn oath have disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Dregan makes three attacks with his hooked warpick.

Hooked Warpick. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) piercing damage (plus Sanction where it applies).

The Question (1/Day). Dregan speaks a zone of truth (DC 15) centered on himself, phrased as courtesy. He has never needed to raise his voice inside one.

Sea-King Aldrec the Landless

Medium humanoid (human, Skell), chaotic neutral — Fighter (raider-king, dying)

Armor Class: 16 (breastplate, sea-worn)

Hit Points: 105 (17d8 + 34)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Str +7, Con +5

Skills: Athletics +7, History +5, Intimidation +6, Persuasion +6

Senses: passive Perception 11

Languages: Common (courtly, better than most courtiers'), Skell

Challenge: 7 (2,900 XP)

The Old Wound. Aldrec is dying, and the block says so: while below half his hit points, at the start of each of his turns he must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or take only one action that turn. His housecarls know the tell — the way his hand finds his side — and close ranks without being told.

Tally-Law. Aldrec has advantage on Insight and Persuasion checks in any negotiation where terms, debts, or oaths are at issue. He counts silently in Skell when angry.

Tide-Roar (Recharge 5–6). A war-shout in a 30-foot cone: each creature must succeed on a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or be deafened and pushed 10 feet (ships' crews have lost boarding actions to the voice alone).

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Aldrec makes three greataxe attacks.

Greataxe ("Collection"). Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 10 (1d12 + 4) slashing damage. The haft is scored with tally-marks. He can tell you what each one is for.

Duke Garvin Norr, the Bastard of Normere

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral – Fighter
(mastermind-general)

Armor Class: 17 (half plate, unadorned)

Hit Points: 120 (18d8 + 39)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)	15 (+2)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Con +5, Int +7

Skills: History +7, Insight +5, Investigation +7

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Normerine ledger-cant

Challenge: 8 (3,900 XP)

The Reckoning. Against any creature Norr has observed for one minute, or any creature sworn to him, his attacks gain advantage and deal an extra 9 (2d8) damage – he fights the way he governs: with complete information. He recites your capabilities aloud as he closes, in a flat voice, from memory.

Terms Offered. Once per combat (free action), Norr states surrender terms. They are exact, survivable, and he will keep them to the letter. Creatures that accept are bound; creatures that refuse grant his allies +1 to attack rolls against them for 1 minute (the Duke's men fight harder against the unreasonable).

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Norr makes three warhammer attacks.

Warhammer. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 9 (1d10 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

REACTIONS

Commander's Stroke. When an ally within 30 feet misses an attack, Norr grants an immediate reroll (3/day). He does not say 'again.' He says the correction.

King Karvel of Ardven

Medium humanoid (human), lawful good – Fighter
(Champion, crowned)

Armor Class: 18 (plate, northern-worked)

Hit Points: 127 (15d10 + 45)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Str +8, Con +6

Skills: Athletics +8, Persuasion +6, Religion +4 (loud, slightly wrong)

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Ardvenner, Common, Orlathine liturgical
(mispronounced with confidence)

Challenge: 8 (3,900 XP)

Crowned Presence. Each creature of Karvel's choice within 30 feet that sees him fight must succeed on a DC 15 Wisdom saving throw or be unable to willingly move away from him for 1 minute – not fear: gravity. Men follow him off cliffs. It is how he made a kingdom.

The Audit. Karvel has advantage on Insight checks against anyone reporting numbers to him. He sleeps four hours. He has personally caught nineteen reeves.

Sweep (Recharge 5–6). Karvel swings through every creature in a 10-foot arc: DC 16 Dexterity save, 18 (4d8) slashing on a failure, half on success.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Karvel makes three greatsword attacks.

Greatsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 12 (2d6 + 5) slashing damage. Critical on 19–20.

Saint-Regent Olvesa the Reconciled

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral – Cleric (Life; true visions)

Armor Class: 13 (sanctified vestments – she has not worn armor in forty-five years)

Hit Points: 117 (18d8 + 36)

Speed: 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	20 (+5)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws: Wis +9, Cha +7

Skills: History +6, Insight +9, Medicine +9, Religion +6

Senses: passive Perception 15

Languages: Orlathine, Common, Old Imperial, Drevic (she has not spoken it aloud in sixty years)

Challenge: 10 (5,900 XP)

The Reconciled. A creature that attempts to attack Olvesa directly must first succeed on a DC 17 Wisdom saving throw (as sanctuary, permanent, self-only) – not divine protection, exactly: the full weight of looking at her and knowing everything she has done and everything she became afterward. On a success, the creature is immune for 24 hours. She has been struck four times in forty-five years. She remembers each one kindly.

True Visions. Olvesa casts as a 13th-level cleric (spell save DC 17): spirit guardians (appearing as gray wolves), flame strike (she weeps when she casts it – the birds), heal, greater restoration, divination – and her divinations are TRUE, which is the entire geopolitical problem.

The Four Movements (DM only). If the campaign ever requires Olvesa at war rather than at prayer, do not build it

as a fight. Build it as a horror scene with a stat block attached. She has not forgotten how. That is what the Reconciliation is FOR.

ACTIONS

Shepherd's Crook. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage. It is a walking stick. She is eighty.

Mistress Averil Shen

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral – Rogue (Mastermind)

Armor Class: 15 (studded leather under gray wool)

Hit Points: 84 (13d8 + 26)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Dex +7, Int +7

Skills: Deception +8, Insight +9, Investigation +10, Perception +6, Sleight of Hand +7, Stealth +10

Senses: passive Perception 16

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, four provincial tongues, three ciphers of her own devising

Challenge: 6 (2,300 XP)

Stillness. Shen has advantage on initiative rolls and can't be surprised while conscious. She has been the calmest person in every room she has ever entered, including this one.

Sneak Attack (5d6). Once per turn, +17 damage against a target she has advantage against or that is engaged with an ally (the Gull counts; the Gull is always somewhere).

Evasion / Uncanny Dodge. As the rogue features.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Shen makes two shortsword attacks (or one, and disappears – Cunning Action).

Letter-Opener (Shortsword). Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage, plus Sneak Attack where it applies. It is, genuinely, her letter-opener.

REACTIONS

Uncanny Dodge. Halve the damage of one attack that hits her. She will thank the attacker afterward, sincerely, for the information.

Prelate Sarvin Odell

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral – Cleric (Knowledge)

Armor Class: 14 (chain shirt under gray robes)

Hit Points: 78 (12d8 + 24)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	18 (+4)	15 (+2)

Saving Throws: Wis +7, Int +6

Skills: History +6, Insight +10, Investigation +6, Religion +9

Senses: passive Perception 14

Languages: Common, Old Imperial, Celestial (liturgical)

Challenge: 5 (1,800 XP)

The File. Odell has advantage on Insight checks against any creature on whom his office holds a file, and he may substitute Religion for Insight when examining claims of divine contact. Assume the file exists.

Spellcasting. 9th-level cleric (spell save DC 15): zone of truth, hold person, tongues, dispel magic, and — his signature — the Invocation of the Sealed Record (as modify memory, used exactly twice in thirty years, both times lawfully, both times filed).

Never By Argument (DM note). Odell's combat statistics are his least relevant numbers. He is beaten by law, by politics, or by the collapse of his case — never by debate and worse than never by violence. If a party attacks him, they have already lost something they cannot get back.

ACTIONS

Weighted Blessing (Mace). Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage (nonlethal, invariably).

Sacred Flame. One creature within 60 feet: DC 15 Dexterity save or 13 (3d8) radiant damage. He apologizes first.

DESIGN VALIDATION NOTES

Block	DMG Band Check (AC / HP / Atk)	Deviation & Role Justification
Qilvayas (CR 9)	18 / 123 (band 109–181) / +8 — all in band	DPR under band: sovereign-support design (aura, 45-pt heal pool, Interposition). Fights defensively by nature and theme.
Thorne (CR 10)	18 / 143 (116–194) / +9 — in band	DPR under band: commander archetype trades damage for battlefield control (maneuvers, Riposte, Ashline) — same pattern as SRD leader-type NPCs.
Dane (CR 7)	18 / 110 (98–162) / +7 — in	AC above band (plate, knight-

	band	standard, RAW). DPR reaches band only with For the Ninth! — leader-aura carries the rest.
Dregan (CR 9)	17 / 130 / +8 — in band	DPR ON band (55) vs. oath-breakers via Sanction; below vs. the innocent — which is the character.
Aldrec (CR 7)	16 / 105 / +7 — in band	DPR under band; Old Wound actively reduces output. Deliberate: a dying king should fight like one.
Norr (CR 8)	17 / 120 (102–170) / +7 — in band	DPR reaches band vs. Reckoned targets (~40). Information-warfare design.
Karvel (CR 8)	18 / 127 / +8 — in band	DPR band-low + Sweep; Crowned Presence is the real weapon.
Olvesa (CR 10)	13 / 117 (116–194, floor) / DC 17	AC far under band — control/support caster protected by the Reconciled (sanctuary-class defense replaces armor). Flame strike AoE meets damage expectations at half-per-target rule.
Shen (CR 6)	15 / 84 (84–140, floor) / +7	Assassin-profile: burst (sneak attack) meets band on opener, under sustained — standard rogue NPC shape (cf. SRD Assassin, CR 8, same pattern).
Odell (CR 5)	14 / 78 (71–119) / DC 15 — in band	Control-role cleric; DPR deliberately trivial. His CR prices his spells and saves, not his mace.

APPENDIX III — HOMEBREW ITEMS OF RECORD

Dren's Oath-Medallion (wondrous, uncommon, unique): A defaced legion oath-medallion, permanently cold, undetectable as magical. While carried openly, the bearer feels it grow colder in the presence of significant oath-breaking, active shadow-residue, or thin-written ground — no mechanics, only truth. It is quieter (Vaelindra's word) in the keeping of those who keep their word.

Oathstone Charm (wondrous, common — Tarnovari): A thumb-sized standing stone on a cord, sworn over at carving. Once per day, when the bearer hears a sworn statement, they may gain advantage on one Insight check to judge its sincerity. Sold openly in Kamenhold; the Stonesworn consider selling them to foreigners either diplomacy or a very long joke.

Pilgrim's Wolfstone (wondrous, common — Church): A shrine-blessed river pebble bearing the Matron's eye. While carried, wolves and dogs regard the bearer as neutral unless provoked, and the bearer knows true north on a clear night. Lupenna sells thousands; perhaps one in forty is 'live.' The Church insists they all are, in the way that matters.

Wardstone Shard (wondrous, common — unique source): A fist-sized fragment of the First Seal's dead wardline. Sheds dim wolf-grey light in a 10-foot radius — and gutters, unmistakably, within 30 feet of Undercourt cold. A canary made of history.

The Lector's Seal (wondrous, rare, unique — the company's stamp): The recovered archival master-key, gifted as the company's sealing-stamp (canon). Documents sealed with it read as genuinely authorized to any mundane inspection within the academy's records system, and the seal cannot be forged — its wax remembers. (Limits: academy archives and their dependencies only; it opens paper, not doors; and every use is, somewhere in the deep stacks, logged.)

DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP — POST-BETA STATUS

As of v10, the D&D-ification pass and the Social Foundations pass are both complete: all names canonical; the Founding Myth, binding site, timeline, both campaign clocks, and the Powers locked; magic and the faith codified (the Weight of the Word, the Sanction, Chartered Thaumaturgy, the night iconography, lycanthropy doctrine, the relic economy); peoples and demographics established (the Founder's Blood, the Stonesworn, the Marked, and the rest); every region fleshed with terrain, creatures, and settlements; three dragon-powers placed; the Roster assigned; ten Powers fully statted (Appendix II); five homebrew items of record (Appendix III); and commerce and loot grounded in SRD pricing; the Packlaw doctrine of gender and authority; the four-tier framework for oaths, service, and bound labor; marriage-as-oath and the Denmother's Choice succession custom; and the twelve-month Imperial Calendar.

Deliberately open by design (not gaps): Nyreeza's exact fate; Countess Ory's blood-rite mechanism; the coronation's metaphysical consequence; whether the Piso gun over Marshal Dane ever fires; whether any line of Threnvos survives; and warlock patron design (sign-off required when built — at least one patron option may trace to the thing beneath Aenodira).

Next development priorities, in order:

1. The Undercourt and the Binding Site: COMPLETE.

Sessions Seven and Eight build the full descent — the price of the Seal, the Vesting Room, the Long Approach, the Witness Hall, and the Rite Floor — through the Vigil and the separation of grief from hunger. The campaign's next frontier is the second arc: the empire itself.

2. Tarnovar Deep Development: Advanced by v8

(Kamenhold, Fencegate, Verath, the Stonesworn, the Old Wood) — still needs the Vosthren ballad cycle in full and the Voivode's court before the envoy thread matures into an arc.

3. The Twin Clocks: Design the Zhuvedian Laws

promulgation and the Grey-Gold Rising (the capital crisis), and the Orlath coronation arc — the mid-campaign's hinge year.

4. The Greywell Module: The Girls of Greywell as a self-

contained gothic horror arc (seeded via Session Five's optional Farrowgate client); decide Ory's mechanism at build time.

5. Sessions Seven and Beyond: Built against party

divergences recorded in the DM Reference Guide's Branch Ledger.

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"We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf"